



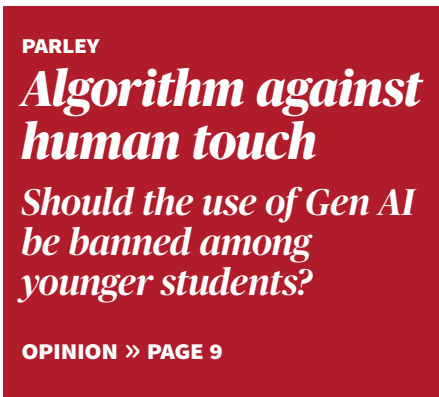
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INSIDE



SC seeks clarity on FSSAI's norms on warning labels

NEW DELHI
The Supreme Court on Thursday asked the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) on how it proposed to determine whether packaged foods were “high” in sugar, salt or fat as part of its front-of-pack warning labels. » **PAGE 4**

Govt. is backing ‘ecocide’ via coal block sale: Cong.

NEW DELHI
The Congress on Thursday accused the Narendra Modi government of supporting “ecocide” by pushing ahead with the auction of the Tara coal block in Hasdeo-Aranya region of Chhattisgarh, despite repeated demands from local communities to protect the dense forests. » **PAGE 5**

Ladakh to get a unique elected body: officials

NEW DELHI
Ladakh Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra said on Thursday that neither Statehood nor a Union Territory (UT) with a legislature is being offered to Ladakh; instead, it will be a *sui generis* model, a unique body under the Constitution that will have legislative, executive, and financial powers. » **PAGE 6**

‘84 days on, EC hasn’t replied to RTI plea on NCPI’

NEW DELHI
The Trinamool Congress on Thursday alleged that the Election Commission (EC) has not responded to a Right to Information (RTI) application seeking information on the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI) though 84 days have passed since application was made. » **PAGE 5**

SC asks Centre to review NEET-SS cut-off decision

Super-specialty medical seats remaining vacant makes a ‘rather compelling’ case for reduction of qualifying percentile, top court says; willing to hold a ‘stray round’ for unfilled seats, says Centre

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court asked the Union government on Thursday to reconsider its decision not to reduce the cut-off percentile for National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test-Super-specialty (NEET-SS) seats in the current year, while expressing concern about a large number of seats going unfilled annually.

The order from a Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe came after Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, for the Centre, said the government was willing to conduct a “stray round” for the vacant NEET-SS seats, but had decided not to lower the qualifying percentile. She said the vacant seats would revert to States such as Tamil Nadu.

The court was hearing a petition filed by the Tamil Nadu Medical Officers Association, represented by senior advocate P. Wilson,

Staking claim

The petition has challenged the ‘premature diversion’ of 152 vacant Super-specialty seats earmarked for in-service government doctors in Tamil Nadu to the all-India quota

What the petition says

■ At least **40 seats** remain vacant from those diverted, and they should be returned to Tamil Nadu

■ Many eligible candidates, mostly in-service government doctors serving in rural parts of the State, are **awaiting a reduction** in the qualifying percentile

■ NEET-SS seats are **‘precious’** and cannot remain vacant



who said Tamil Nadu had 40 vacant seats left, and they should be returned to the State. The petitioner-association had challenged the “premature diversion” of 152 vacant super-specialty seats earmarked for in-service government doctors in Tamil Nadu to the all-India quota. It had also sought protection of the State’s in-service reservation policy, pending a final decision on reduction of the NEET-SS qualifying percentile.

Mr. Wilson stressed that

many eligible candidates, mostly in-service government doctors serving in rural parts of the State, were awaiting a reduction in the qualifying percentile. He said the NEET-SS seats were “precious”, and cannot remain vacant.

Senior advocate Abhishhek Manu Singhvi, for Tamil Nadu, said the State wanted the vacant seats to completely revert to it. He further urged the top court to lower the cut-off percentile.

The court said the fact

that many seats remain unfilled makes the case for reduction of the qualifying percentile “rather compelling”.

Justice Narasimha advised the Additional Solicitor-General to “reflect a little more” about bringing down the percentile, and even consult with other members of the Bar on the issue.

Ms. Bhati urged the court then to “add a line” in its order “directing us to reconsider this... to consider reduction to the extent possible”.

The law officer revealed that even some of the experts had “varying views” on the question of lowering the qualifying percentile.

“Some amount of reduction can be made. For last years, we had even reduced it [qualifying percentile] to 0%,” Ms. Bhati submitted.

The court scheduled the case for further hearing and directions on September 17.

Take action against threats to minor NEET protester: SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday asked Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta to ensure “immediate action” on a complaint filed by a 14-year-old student, who alleged open threats and harassment from miscreants for her role in the protests against NEET-UG question paper leaks.

“These are anti-social elements. They commit violence against a child, and they roam free. Now, they are again trying to browbeat and intimidate the child and her family, so that they do not proceed with any legal action. This is a very serious issue. Her cause is absolutely justified,” Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, heading a three-judge Bench, observed.

Out of respect for the teenager’s privacy and safety, the Bench did not name her and asked her lawyer not to mention it in open court while live-streaming was on.

FULL REPORT ON
» **PAGE 4**

India-Canada trade deal by the end of the year, says envoy

Suhasini Haidar
T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The India-Canada trade deal will be ready by the end of the year, Canadian High Commissioner Christopher Cooter has told *The Hindu*, adding that the two countries are planning for their increased engagement this year to culminate in a visit by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the North American country in December.

Speaking at *The Hindu Mind* in New Delhi on Wednesday, Mr. Cooter said that the two countries had ample opportunities for bilateral investment which could scale up to \$1 trillion.

He did, however, point out that India could ease some tax and regulatory hurdles to spur further investment, something on which Canada has been engaging with the Union Finance Ministry.

“Previously, we discussed for 12 years, and we got no trade agreement,” Mr. Cooter said. “This time, we started in March 2026. We have probably done more in these six months than we did in those 12 years.” “I am pretty confident the trade deal will be agreed to by the end of the year,” he said. “Our hope is we get there by the time of a Modi visit to Canada, which would mean achieving this in about nine months [since March],” the Canadian High Commissioner said.

Big investments

Mr. Cooter acknowledged that while trade is currently small (about US\$8 billion), the investment relationship between the two countries is a strong one, with a large space to grow.

“So, you actually provide good employment for 1,00,000 Canadians in Canada through Indian investment in Canada,” Mr. Cooter said. “The other part of the story is that, while trade itself is rather small, the pension funds and other big institutional investors have about \$100-110 billion Canadian dollars or \$80 billion U.S. dollars in investment in India.”

“...the difference with Canadian investment is that our investment



Christopher Cooter

through these institutional investors is also direct investment”. “We estimate that no less than 75% of all our investment through those funds is in physical assets. And no other country has that,” he added. “So, those create not just tens of thousands, those create hundreds of thousands of jobs.”

Bigger potential

Looking ahead, Mr. Cooter noted that most of Canada’s mining assets were abroad, but “virtually none” of them were in India. “If you were to deregulate, I am pretty certain our hundreds of Canadian mining companies would come in here, start exploring, start mining, helping with processing, technology, etc,” he said. “That’s an example where we might invest in your country.”

“And you might invest in, let’s say, a tungsten mine in Canada because tungsten is useful for your defence industry,” Mr. Cooter added. “We’ve got the things that you actually need, like energy. We’re the fourth largest in oil, fifth largest in LPG, and fifth largest in LNG. We have 20% of the world’s potash and number 2 or 3 in titanium.”

He emphasised that Canadian funds and companies were eager to invest more and there were some issues India could address to enable that. “There are some tax issues,” Mr. Cooter said. “...That’s a discussion we are having now with the Finance Ministry in particular. There are things that slow the investment a little bit. You could take some more steps to deregulate. That would actually make the environment for Canadian investment even better.”

EDITORIAL
» **PAGE 8**

Golden bulbs



Soaring hopes: A farmer carries freshly harvested onions in a field near Chikkamagaluru, Karnataka, on Thursday. To curb rising prices, the Centre recently sold 4,000 tonnes of buffer stocks as part of subsidised sales as wholesale prices hit ₹42.79 per kg on September 5. PTI

Chinese President Xi to visit India for BRICS summit; boost to normalisation process

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

China announced on Thursday that President Xi Jinping will attend the BRICS Summit in New Delhi this weekend, on what will be his first visit to India in almost seven years.

Mr. Xi last visited in October 2019 for an informal summit with Prime Minister Narendra Modi at Ma-mallapuram in Tamil Nadu. The two leaders are expected to meet for bilateral talks on the sidelines

of the coming summit in New Delhi.

Mr. Xi will be accompanied by a large delegation, including Politburo member and Foreign Minister Wang Yi, and Commerce Minister Wang Wentao, who is likely to have talks on the sidelines with Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, his counterpart.

The talks between the two Ministers will give both sides the opportunity to take stock of a growing but challenging trade relationship and air their res-



Xi Jinping

pective concerns, with India seeking an easing of export controls and China wanting further relaxation of investment restrictions.

Mr. Xi’s visit in itself

holds enormous significance for the relationship in the view of India and Chinese officials, and for the continued normalisation process. Especially on the Chinese side, a visit by Mr. Xi to India, after a seven-year gap, is seen as important signalling to the Chinese system on where relations are headed after a difficult period.

Border tensions starting in April 2020, culminating in a clash at Galwan Valley in June, brought a four-year freeze in relations.

Following a meeting between Mr. Modi and Mr. Xi in October 2024 on the sidelines of the BRICS summit in Kazan, China, in August have begun a gradual and steady normalisation in relations.

Mr. Modi and Mr. Xi last met at the SCO Summit in Tianjin, China, in August last year, when they both “welcomed the positive momentum and steady progress in bilateral relations” and “reaffirmed that the two countries were development partners and

not rivals, and that their differences should not turn into disputes.”

In China, the visit by Mr. Xi is being seen as an effort by both sides to keep ties stable, rather than as an indicator of any significant realignment.

“I would describe it as strategic risk management rather than strategic realignment,” Hu Shisheng, Director of the South Asia Institute at the China Institutes of Contemporary International Relations in Beijing told *The Hindu* in a

recent interview.

“Recent difficulties in India-U.S. relations may give New Delhi greater incentives to diversify its strategic options, while the relative stabilisation of China-U.S. ties reduces some of the external pressure on China-India relations. But the structural differences between China and India have not disappeared. What we are seeing is an attempt to build a more stable form of competitive coexistence - keeping the border peaceful, restoring

practical cooperation, and expanding coordination through BRICS and the Global South without pre-empting that strategic competition no longer exists.”

During talks in Beijing last month, both National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and Mr. Wang highlighted the positive impact that meetings between the leadership had on the relationship in setting the trajectory.

LEADERS CONVERGE
» **PAGE 4**

ED concludes raids at houses of Satish Jarkiholi and aides

The Hindu Bureau
BELAGAVI

Officers from the Enforcement Directorate (ED) concluded their search of the houses of Karnataka Public Works Minister Satish Jarkiholi, and some of his relatives and key associates, in multiple places on Thursday.

ED personnel showed up at the houses of Mr. Satish Jarkiholi, his children Priyanka and Rahul, and brother-in-law Y. Manjunath. Mr. Manjunath is a Joint Commissioner in the Excise Department.

However, the ED officers did not visit the houses or offices of the Minister's brothers Ramesh and Balachandra Jarkiholi, both BJP MLAs. There are no reports of a search in the houses of independent

MLC Lakhan Jarkiholi or Bhimshi Jarkiholi, a businessman. Both are younger brothers of the Minister. The premises of Mr. Ramesh Jarkiholi were searched by the Income Tax Department in 2017. Officers also searched the houses of Laxmi Hebbalkar, who was considered his close associate.

ED personnel also searched the houses, offices, and commercial properties of the Minister's close friends and associates Girish Sonwalkar, Raju Daragasheety, and Vithal Parasannavar.

Dr. Sonwalkar is a native of Mudalagi village near Gokak and is a professor in Belagavi Institute of Medical Sciences. Mr. Daragasheety and Mr. Parasannavar are Gokak-based businessmen.

Karnataka limits rendition of Vande Mataram to 2 stanzas

The government order says that all six stanzas will be played at functions involving the President, V-P, Prime Minister or Governor; acknowledges the National Song's role in 'instilling nationalism'

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Karnataka government has issued an order stating that only the first two stanzas of the National Song *Vande Mataram* are to be sung at State functions. The stand is in line with that of the Congress at the national level.

However, the entire six stanzas will be played or sung in functions involving the President, Vice-President, Prime Minister, or Governor, the order states. The order, issued by the Department of Personnel and Administrative Reforms (DIPR), follows a Cabinet decision.

The order acknowledg-



The order issued by Department of Personnel and Administrative Reforms follows a decision by the State Cabinet. FILE PHOTO

es that *Vande Mataram* played an important role in instilling nationalism, unity, and patriotism among the people of the country during the Indian national movement for freedom.

It refers to the guide-

lines issued by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs prescribing the singing of the official version of the song, as well as the procedure to be followed while singing or playing it at various government and pu-

BJP slams order on National Song

NEW DELHI

The BJP on Thursday questioned the Karnataka Congress government over its order on *Vande Mataram*. BJP spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi said the Congress had become completely isolated from all its alliance partners on the issue, and only the Muslim League remained with it.

blic programmes.

However, the order says that the State government has considered the need to maintain 'uniformity, dignity and appropriate protocol' with regard to the singing of *Vande Mataram*.



Rescue operation under way at the site of an under-construction church near Katpadi in Vellore on Thursday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

3 killed, 11 hurt as church scaffolding collapses in Vellore

The Hindu Bureau
VELLORE

Three workers, including a father and son, were killed and 11 others injured after the scaffolding of an under-construction church at a village in Vellore district collapsed on Thursday.

The deceased were identified as John 40, Samuel 67, and his son Immanuel alias Kutty, 32. All of them hailed from Bengaluru.

Six workers – Mariti, 29; Praveen Kumar, 40; Maish Vadhan, 42; Issac Newton, 61; Perumal, 45; and Ashok Kumar, 31 – were admitted to the Government Medical College and Hospital near Vellore. "One person each was brought dead to the Vellore Government Hospital and Christian Medical College, Ranipet. One worker was found dead," DHO M. Vijay Chandran told *The Hindu*.

Three other workers – Jones, 50, David, 50, and Rajesh, 30 – were admitted to Christian Medical College, Ranipet. Two oth-

ers were shifted to a private hospital in Chittoor, Andhra Pradesh.

The police said the CSI church had been under construction for the past few months at Manji Krishnapuram, around 10 km from Katpadi. Workers from surrounding villages and Bengaluru were brought in to build the church.

The police said that as part of roof-laying on Thursday, steel scaffolding was erected at a height of 20 feet to allow 20 workers to work on the top of the structure.

Around 3.45 p.m., the scaffolding of the roof collapsed. Workers were trapped in concrete mixture debris and scaffolding.

On information, the police from Tiruvalam and Katpadi rushed to the spot, along with firefighters from Vellore and Chittoor. The first batch of six workers was rescued around 5 p.m. Later, NDRF teams from Arakkonam joined the rescue operation.

CPI(M) slams ED move against Pinarayi

The Hindu Bureau
KANNUR

Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)] general secretary M.A. Baby on Thursday accused the Enforcement Directorate (ED) of functioning as an "extended department of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)" and said the agency would soon realise that CPI (M) leaders would not join the BJP out of fear of investigation.

He was responding to the ED's latest move involving the CPI(M) leadership

and said the agency had made a big mistake by targeting the party. He said the issue now being raised by the ED had already been taken up before the courts by a Congress legislator during the tenure of Pinarayi Vijayan as Chief Minister. The legislator had first approached the Vigilance Court seeking an investigation against Mr. Vijayan and others, but the court rejected the plea.

The matter was subsequently taken to the High Court and later to the Supreme Court where the

plea was rejected, he said. "There is nothing more to say about it. The CPI(M) has already made its position clear," he said, adding that the party would reject with contempt the "ED's attempt to target the party leadership."

'Double standard'

Mr. Baby also criticised the Congress leadership in Kerala, particularly Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan, for attaching importance to the ED action. He said the Congress leaders had adopted a different posi-

tion when Central investigating agencies targeted their own leaders.

Meanwhile in a statement, CPI(M) Polit Bureau on Thursday said it was "evident from the outset" that the investigation against Ms. Veena was 'only a pretext' to target Mr. Vijayan.

It further said that the endorsement of the Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee president Sunny Joseph of the ED action and his demand for a case to be registered exposes the "double standards" of the party.

Karnataka CM marks 100 days in office

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Seeking to make Karnataka a "model state", Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Thursday unveiled a slew of initiatives, including the Seva One digital citizen services platform, the Chief Minister Raitha Chaitanya scheme and the BMTG 2.0 mobile application, aimed at taking governance and public services closer to the people.

Marking the completion of 100 days of his government under the tagline "Drudha Karnataka Sankalpa", Mr. Shivakumar also approved a scheme to distribute five lakh housing sites to landless people, particularly in rural areas, in the current fiscal year.

On women's safety, he said the government would establish squads in every police circle and station to act against gangs and habitual offenders.

INBRIEF



ACB catches two employees accepting ₹1 lakh bribe

The Anti-Corruption Bureau on Thursday caught an employee of the Telangana Secretariat and another of the Telangana State Industrial Development Corporation (TSIDC) while they were accepting a ₹1 lakh bribe for processing a medical reimbursement claim under the Chief Minister's Relief Fund (CMRF) scheme. The accused were Anandeshi Raghavender, an outsourcing employee at the Secretariat, and Medi Vinod, a senior assistant at the TSIDC office, Basheerbagh. ACB officials caught the two red-handed and recovered the amount.

TDB to ramp up Aravana production for Sabarimala

With just over three months to go for the annual pilgrimage season at Sabarimala, the Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) has begun work to ramp up the daily production capacity of *Aravana*, the temple's most popular offering. Work is under way at the *Aravana* plant at the Sannidhanam to add six preparation pans, two cooling chambers, and a boiler. The expansion will increase the plant's daily production capacity by 85,000 to one lakh containers, TDB officials said. The work is expected to be completed by October.

Telangana allocates ₹240 cr. for Employees Health Scheme

The Telangana government has constituted a corpus of ₹240 crore for the effective implementation of the Employees Health Scheme envisaging cashless treatment for government employees in empanelled hospitals. The government is also implementing ₹1 crore accidental cover for employees. The accidental cover scheme extends to 12.91 lakh employees, as of now. These include 5.18 lakh regular staff, 5.01 lakh staff on contract, outsourcing, work charged and other categories, and 2.72 lakh pensioners and their eligible dependents.

Two A.P. students try to harm classmate to get 'holiday', expelled

The Hindu Bureau
MADANAPALLE

Two Class 8 students of a Gurukul Patashala in Annamayya district of Andhra Pradesh were issued transfer certificates (TCs) from the school following allegations that they attempted to harm a classmate while he was asleep in the hostel.

According to officials, the student approached the Mandal Education Department and alleged that the two boys had pressed his neck with their feet during the incident. He reportedly managed to escape and subsequently brought the matter to the notice of the authorities.

During an inquiry con-

A Mandal Education Officer probed the incident, which reportedly happened a week ago

ducted by Mandal Education Officer Reddy Basha on Wednesday, the two students reportedly acknowledged their involvement in the incident, which took place a week ago. Officials said that the boys allegedly told the inquiry team that they believed a death in the residential school would lead to a one-day holiday.

As an interim measure, the Education authorities issued transfer certificates to the two students.

'Djinn show' at healing centre in Keralam sparks protest

The Hindu Bureau
MALAPPURAM

Residents forcibly shut down a healing centre at Tirunavaya in Malappuram, Keralam, following allegations of fraud in the name of "djinn-related healing". Organisers of the centre claimed that people from across Keralam visited the centre seeking healing. At a programme held last Sunday, a man was reportedly presented as being possessed by a "djinn".

Videos of the programme later circulated on social media, prompting criticism. The incident triggered protests by residents, who confronted the organisers and shut down the centre.

Karnataka HC dismisses govt. notices authorising 2% welfare cess on film tickets

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The High Court of Karnataka on Thursday quashed the circulars and notices issued by the regulatory authorities asking the multiplexes and cinema theatres to collect 2% welfare cess with effect from September 1 under the provisions of the Karnataka Cine and Cultural Activists (Welfare) Act, 2024.

The State government admitted that the Act itself is yet to come into force.

Justice H.T. Narendra Prasad passed the order while allowing the petition filed by the Multiplex Association of India and PVR INOX Ltd.



Notices issued by authorities asked theatres to collect the 2% cess from September 1.

Earlier, the government informed the court that notices were withdrawn on September 9 while admitting that Gazette notification announcing the date from which the Act would come into force, was yet to be issued.

The petitioners had challenged the legality of issuing circulars and notices when the Act itself had not come into force, as the government had not notified the date for giving effect to the Act after it had received the Governor's assent on September 23, 2024, and was published in the Gazette.

As the petitioners had also challenged the legality of the Act, the court said that examination of the legality of the Act would not arise at this stage as the Act is yet to be enforced, while reserving the liberty to the petitioners to challenge the legality of the legislation as and when it comes into force.

Ganesh Agamans turn into major celebrations in Hyderabad

Abhinav Deshpande
HYDERABAD

There are no concert tickets, no reflective wristbands and no DJ or popular singer on stage. But thousands are dancing to *dhol-tasha* and music, streets are lit up like event venues and fireworks light up the night sky. This is *Ganesh Agaman* (arrival of the Lord) in Hyderabad.

What was once largely a neighbourhood affair is turning into a city-wide spectacle, with people travelling from across Hyderabad and neighbouring districts to watch *Agamans* – the arrival of Ganesha. In several localities, the crowds, music, lights and fireworks are beginning to resemble a music concert or a sporting event.

Social media spotlight

Dhol-tasha groups from neighbouring Maharashtra are being brought in, *bhajan* clubs are joining the celebrations, youngsters are turning up in fusion outfits and organisers are competing with elaborate decorations inspired by celebrations in North India and elsewhere.



An idol of Lord Ganesha being transported to a *pandal* ahead of Ganesh Chaturthi in Hyderabad on Thursday. NAGARA GOPAL

Social media has added another layer to the festivities. Ganesh committees are creating dedicated Instagram pages and collaborating with influencers to showcase idol-making, preparations and *Agaman*. Influencers are also travelling to popular *pandals* to film the preparations and

processions.

Lists of "must-visit" Ganesh *pandals* are circulating online, with Khairatabad, Balapur, Begum Bazaar Pahlwan Ganesh and Ramnagar ka Raja, some of Hyderabad's original and decades-old *pandals*, featuring prominently.

The change is also in the timing. Several *Agamans* were held in the last week of August and the first week of September, well ahead of Ganesh Chaturthi on September 14.

In Ramnagar, a 19-year-old engineering student died while participating in the *Agaman* procession on Saturday. Police said a crowd of nearly 10,000 people had gathered for the procession.

Value for politicians

There is another visible change this year: political leaders are taking a greater interest in Ganesh committees and their celebrations.

With the municipal elections looming, neighbourhood-level visibility has acquired added value for political leaders. Sponsor-

ing or associating with a Ganesh committee offers politicians an opportunity to be present in localities where conventional political programmes may not always attract large crowds.

"*Agaman* is not new, but the scale of the celebrations is touching a different level this year...", said Shashidhar Ravinuthala, general secretary of the Bhagyanagar Ganesh Utsav Samiti.

Citing a study by the Central University of Karnataka, he said, "Five years ago, they conducted a study and found that the economy was worth over ₹6,000 crore, directly benefiting more than two lakh families and indirectly helping over four lakh individuals."

Magistrate suspended over NEET protest notice

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta informed the Supreme Court on Thursday about the suspension of an Executive Magistrate of the Greater Noida Commissionerate who issued show-cause notice to a student of Gautam Buddha University in connection with the recent protests at Jantar Mantar. The Magistrate issued the notice on September 4 despite a Supreme Court order three days earlier, prohibiting coercive measures against students.

On September 9, the top court made its displeasure clear about the Magistrate's issuance of the notice to Akshat Tripathi under Section 130 of Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita in connection with preventive proceedings.

Mr. Tripathi had been called upon to show cause as to why he should not be bound to execute a personal bond of ₹5 lakh with two sureties for allegedly "instigating" fellow students to join a proposed dharna of the Cockroach Janta Party.

The CJI had observed that the Magistrate had no authority to issue such a notice "when we have already annulled [FIRs] and directed that no penal action would be taken against any student".

Wars, global crises may top agenda of BRICS summit

Vladimir Putin, Xi Jinping, UN Secretary-General Guterres are among top leaders set to attend the summit scheduled for this weekend; Putin is likely to hold bilateral meeting with Modi today

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Russian President Vladimir Putin is expected to arrive here on Friday morning to attend the 18th BRICS summit that will be held here this weekend, Russian sources said.

Mr. Putin is likely to hold a bilateral meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi hours after his arrival, where the two sides are expected to discuss defence and other related matters. Mr. Putin is among the top leaders of BRICS members and partner countries who are scheduled to arrive for the September 12-13 summit.

Several heads of multilateral organisations, including United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres, are also scheduled to attend the BRICS summit.

The External Affairs Ministry has confirmed that, apart from Mr. Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping, Egyptian President Abdel Fattah El-Sisi, Ethiopia's Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed Ali, and Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto are among the top leaders who are expected to reach Delhi for the summit that is being held against the backdrop



Centre of attention: Flags of various countries on display as preparations for the 18th BRICS summit are under way at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi on Thursday. PTI

of a global crisis in the supply chains of energy and agriculture because of wars in West Asia and Ukraine.

The conflict in West Asia that started in February, when Israel and the U.S. launched a joint attack on Iran, is likely to be among the top topics of the summit, especially as Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian is scheduled to be here. This will be the first visit to India by Mr. Pezeshkian since he took charge after the death of President

Ebrahim Raisi in 2024.

Mr. Pezeshkian met Mr. Modi on the sidelines of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyz Republic, on August 31. That was the first meeting between the two leaders since the war began.

The differences between Iran and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) will be keenly watched as the two sides have been exchanging tough messages because of the ongoing hostilities in the region.

The UAE will be represented by Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, the Ministry informed. The Gulf Cooperation Council, which is also in focus because of the hostilities in the Persian Gulf region, will be represented by Abdullah bin Rashid Al Zayani, Foreign Minister of Bahrain. Among the founding members of BRICS, South Africa will be represented by Cyril Ramaphosa and Brazil will be represented by Mauro Vieira.

NSCN-IM wants to create fresh fault lines to divert attention: Kuki-Zo groups

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The spokesperson of a Kuki-Zo insurgent group in peace talks with the government said on Thursday that the ongoing unrest in Manipur was not a "Naga-Kuki conflict", and alleged, instead, that certain elements linked to the National Socialist Council of Nagaland (Isak-Muivah) [NSCN-IM] were making attempts to manufacture such a narrative to serve their own interests.

The ethnic violence in Manipur, which began as clashes between the Meitei and Kuki communities on May 3, 2023, has, since February 7, 2026, expanded to include violence between sections of the Naga and Kuki communities.

Seilen Haokip of the Kuki National Organisation (KNO), one of the two Kuki insurgent groupings in suspension of operations (SoO) pact with the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) and the Manipur government, said there was a deliberate effort to spread violence beyond existing conflict zones and draw the Naga and Kuki communities into a broader confrontation. The violence was not spontaneous, he said, adding that the objective was to divert attention from internal challenges within the



The Kuki-Zo People's Forum, including spokespersons of insurgent groups in suspension of operations pact, at a press conference in New Delhi on Thursday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

NSCN-IM and revive support for the outfit by creating fresh fault lines in the hill districts.

NSCN-IM, the largest Naga insurgent group, signed a ceasefire agreement with the Government of India in 1997 and, in 2015, signed a framework agreement to find a political solution to their demands.

On September 2, 2025, the MHA and the Manipur government extended the 2008 SoO agreement with the KNO and the United People's Front (UPF) on "renegotiated terms and conditions or ground rules." The revised ground rules reiterated territorial integrity of Manipur and relocation of camps run by the insurgent groups away from Meitei-dominated areas in the valley districts. The SoO groups have been demanding a Union Territory with legislature for the Kuki-Zo people.

Aron Kipgen, UPF's spokesperson criticised recent security operations by central forces, including searches and raids on SoO camps, contending that such actions violated established ground rules that require coordination with local police and adherence to the SoO agreement.

He accused the Manipur government of adopting a discriminatory approach towards Kuki-Zo communities and reiterated their demand for a separate administrative arrangement. He said the ongoing conflict, displacement of people and disruptions to the movement of essential supplies had reinforced calls for governance directly under the Centre.

He said their proposal seeking a separate administrative arrangement for the Kuki-Zo people had been pending with the MHA since 2024.

Take action against threats to minor NEET protester: SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday asked Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta to ensure "immediate action" on a complaint filed by a 14-year-old student, who alleged open threats and harassment from miscreants for her role in the protests against NEET-UG question paper leaks.

"These are anti-social elements. They commit violence against a child, and they roam free. Now, they are again trying to browbeat and intimidate the child and her family, so that they do not proceed with any legal action. This is a very serious issue. Her cause is absolutely justified," Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, heading a three-judge Bench, observed.

The student's counsel submitted that a "vigilante" had "bragged" on social media about the hurt caused to her and her family. "She is a bona fide victim. She is also a vulnerable victim. No irreversible harm should befall the child or her family," the lawyer said.

Justice Joymalya Bagchi, part of the Bench with Justice V. Mohana, said the Uttar Pradesh Police should take responsibility for the safety of the student and her family.

"The FIR in the Parliament Street police station relates to allegations of miscreants threatening, harassing, intimidating and having indulged in acts of violence against her. If they are true, we would like you to take immediate action on the FIR, and file a report here. Police protection must be given to the victim and family by the police in Uttar Pradesh where she is presently claiming to reside," Justice

The Bench said U.P. Police should take responsibility for the safety of the student and her family

Bagchi addressed the top law officer.

Recently, the Delhi Police had arrested Hindutva influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj in connection with the alleged assault on the father of a student during the NEET-UG protests. Mr. Bhardwaj was detained in Bulandshahr after the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) had staged a protest outside Parliament Street police station.

The counsel for the student argued that vulnerable victims like her client should be able to safeguard their privacy by directly approaching the top court or accessing the Supreme Court-appointed High-Powered Enquiry Committee (HPEC), which was set up to investigate police and anti-social excesses against protesting students.

"The committee is our extended hand. Whatever the committee does and finds, it will be placed before us only. Protection of vulnerable witnesses should not be less than that given in judicial proceedings... There should not be any obstacle to access for vulnerable victims," Chief Justice Kant observed.

Senior advocate N. Hariharan asked who would register FIRs if the HPEC found police officers liable for the excesses committed against protestors.

"Once a cognisable offence is made out, who will register the FIRs? Will the Supreme Court or HPEC order the registration? Will the police investigate their own case?" Mr. Hariharan asked the court.

SC seeks clarity on FSSAI's warning label norms

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday questioned the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) on how it proposed to determine whether packaged foods were "high" in sugar, salt or fat as part of its proposed front-of-pack warning labels, as it underlined that food safety was a cause of "national interest".

The FSSAI had last month proposed prominent red warning labels on packaged foods high in added fat, added sugar or salt, marking a regulatory pivot after the top court questioned its reluctance

to introduce such warnings.

In an affidavit filed before the court, the food regulator said the labels would take the form of a red hexagonal warning on the front of packages where a product was found to be high in two or more specified nutrients of concern — fat, sugar or salt. The thresholds would be based on those prescribed under the Dietary Guidelines for Indians, 2024, issued by the ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition (NIN).

FSSAI's affidavit

A Bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and K. Vinod Chandan, while examining the FSSAI's affidavit, however,



questioned how the regulator would determine the threshold beyond which a packaged food would be classified as "high" in sugar, salt or fat. "If you ask them to put a label, say high in salt, high in sugar, high in sodium, high in potassium, how will you de-

termine it? Have you laid down any guidelines?" the Bench asked. Additional Solicitor-General Brijender Chahar, appearing for the Centre and the FSSAI, said the regulator was adhering to the guidelines issued by the ICMR-NIN.

The Bench was hearing a public interest litigation petition filed by non-profit organisations seeking warning labels on packaged foods to indicate high levels of salt, sugar and saturated fats. On Thursday, it indicated that it would soon pass a detailed order seeking further information from the stakeholders.

"We have done some homework and undertaken some study. We pro-

pose to pass an order calling for some further information from you. Study the order and come back with an appropriate further report," Justice Pardiwala told Mr. Chahar.

"Take orders seriously" The top court also asked the regulator to take its directions "seriously", stressing its concern over the impact of food safety standards on public health. "We are concerned with the health of people, more particularly growing children... We have taken it up very seriously... We expect one and all to extend cooperation in a cause which is in national interest," Justice Pardiwala said.

17 foreigners in jail after completing sentence: HC

The Hindu Bureau

The High Court of Meghalaya has found 17 foreign nationals lodged in a Meghalaya jail despite having completed their sentences.

A team assigned by the High Court visited the Shillong District Jail and found that a Myanmar national has been languishing behind bars for more than 10 years, while a Nigerian and fifteen Bangladeshi nationals have spent between six months and a couple of years. The team ascertained facilities, legal aid.

Biotech Conclave to shed light on role of life sciences in shaping the future

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The VIT Chennai-Biotech Conclave 2026, to be held in Chennai today, will bring together leading experts, industry leaders and academicians for a dialogue on the growing role of biotechnology in shaping the future.

Conceived as a student-centric platform, the conclave seeks to introduce higher secondary students, undergraduates, researchers and biotechnology aspirants to the opportunities, challenges and real-world impact of biotechnology.

The conclave will be inaugurated by Suchitra Ella, co-founder and managing director of Bharat Biotech, and CII-president designate. The programme will be presided over by G. Viswanathan, founder and chancellor of Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT). G.V. Selvam, vice-president, VIT, will deliver the special address.

Speaking about the con-



clave, Mr. Selvam said, "Through this conclave, VIT Chennai aims to encourage students to see biotechnology not only as a field of study, but as a pathway to innovation, enterprise and meaningful service to humanity."

The opening session will feature a direct interaction between students and Ms. Ella, offering participants an opportunity to engage with one of India's leading biotechnology entrepreneurs.

Also, Ganapathy, honorary distinguished professor, Indian Institute of Management-Jammu, distinguished professor, The Tamil Nadu Dr. M.G.R. Medical University and emeritus professor, Na-

tional Academy of Medical Sciences; Mayur Abhaya, managing director, LifeCell International; and Shridevi S, deputy director, Centre for NeuroInformatics, VIT Chennai, will discuss the convergence of technology and biotechnology in conversation with Zubeda Hamid, senior assistant editor, The Hindu.

Vinod Scaria, chief data officer, Karkinos Healthcare; Kalpana Gowrishankar, clinical geneticist and counsellor, Apollo Hospitals; and G. Jayaraman, dean, School of Bio Sciences and Technology, VIT Chennai, will discuss the movement of gene-based technologies from laboratories into clinical and public health contexts, in conversation with Geetha Srimathi. S, senior reporter, The Hindu.

Maneesh Paul, CEO, Microvioma, lead co-inventor and program director of the anti-infective Enmetazobactam, Orchid Pharma; Vasanthambandamurthy, senior vice-president, Bug-

works Research India Pvt. Ltd.; and M.M. Balamurali, professor, Centre for Healthcare Advancement, Innovation and Research, VIT Chennai, will join Athira Elssa Johnson, senior reporter, The Hindu, in a discussion on India's emergence as a global biopharma hub.

The funding landscape for biotech research in India will be explored by Ajay Mahipal, co-founder and general partner, HealthKois, in conversation with Serena Josephine M., special correspondent, The Hindu. The last session will feature K. Vijayaraghavan of National Centre for Biological Sciences, Tata Institute of Fundamental Research, in conversation with Jacob Koshy, Science Editor, The Hindu. It will explore India's research and innovation ecosystem.

To watch the event live, scan the QR code or visit newsth.live/VITBTCLS



SC rejects 1993 blasts convict Abu Salem's petition for release

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday dismissed a plea by 1993 Mumbai serial blasts convict Abu Salem seeking release from prison on the ground that he had completed the required 25-year jail term.

Mr. Salem was extradited from Portugal to India in 2005 after a sovereign assurance that he would neither be sentenced to death nor imprisoned for more than 25 years.

Following his extradition, he was sentenced to life imprisonment by special courts under the Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Act (TADA) in 2015 for the 1995 murder of businessman Pradeep Jain and in 2017 for his role in the 1993 Mumbai serial blasts.

In view of the sovereign assurance given to Portugal, the Supreme Court in July 2022 commuted the

life sentences imposed on Salem in the two cases to a maximum term of 25 years.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said it found "no infirmity" in the Bombay High Court's April 15 ruling dismissing his petition for release, holding that the sovereign assurance could not be used to claim an "artificial or accelerated" computation of his period of incarceration. It said Salem's claim for release could not be divorced from the "gravity" of crimes for which he was convicted, which included attempts to "destabilise" the nation.

Before the top court, senior advocate Rishi Malhotra, appearing for Mr. Salem, had argued that the 25-year jail term should be calculated from September 18, 2002, when he was detained in Portugal following a Red Corner Notice issued by Interpol at India's instance.

INBRIEF



Under-construction bridge collapses in Bihar; 7 injured

Seven people were injured after a portion of an under-construction bridge collapsed in Bihar's Vaishali district on Thursday. The bridge is part of the Bharatmala Pariyojana – a Union Road Transport and Highways Ministry scheme to build and improve road networks. The incident took place during the four-lane construction work. After receiving information, Vaishali SP Shubhank Mishra and SDPO Gopal Mandal inspected the site. “First aid was provided to all the injured of whom three individuals have been referred to Sadar Hospital, Hajipur, for better treatment,” Vaishali Police said.

India, U.S. armies commence bilateral exercise Yudh Abhyas

The Indian and United States armies have begun the 22nd edition of their annual bilateral military exercise, Yudh Abhyas 2026, with a focus on high-altitude warfare, long-range precision fires, counter-drone capabilities, and greater operational interoperability. According to an official statement, the exercise, being held from September 9 to 28, saw the deployment of Arctic-trained soldiers from the U.S. Army, based in Alaska, for high-altitude training in India. The exercise also includes the participation of the U.S. Army's 3rd Multi-Domain Task Force.

No Statehood, Ladakh to get unique elected body, says Chief Secretary

Home Ministry discusses the proposed structure of the UT-level body under Article 371 at a meeting with LAB and KDA; Ladakh leaders call the meeting a ‘waste of time and money’, say Ministry and UT administration are not on the same page

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Ladakh Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra said on Thursday that neither Statehood nor a Union Territory (UT) with a legislature is being offered to Ladakh; instead, it will be a *sui generis* model, a unique body under the Constitution that will have legislative, executive, and financial powers.

Mr. Kundra, while responding to a question by *The Hindu* on whether the head of the elected body will be called a Chief Minister and whether the assurance was akin to restoring Statehood for Ladakh, said, “Ladakh was never a State. It was part of J&K, and later it became a UT. Aspiration of the people is to have legislative, executive, and financial powers. An agreement has been reached with the leadership here, a *sui generis* model, which does not exist anywhere in the country, will be crafted for Ladakh, where a legislative body will be created. It is not go-



Civil Society members from Ladakh, including Sonam Wangchuk, address a press conference in New Delhi. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ing to be Statehood for sure or a UT with legislature, but it is some other body which will have these powers, the nomenclature is yet to be finalised, that is why discussions are on.”

The Chief Secretary informed that at a meeting with the Leh Apex Body (LAB) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) on September 9, the proposed structure of the UT-level body under Article 371 of the Constitution was discussed, and the members expressed their consensus

on having a “direct election through constituencies” for the UT-level body.

He said the members have been given a list of eight to nine questions to examine the structural relationship and distribution of powers between the existing hill councils and the proposed UT-level body as per their requirements. The next round of discussions is expected in October.

Emphasising that constitutional safeguards require a detailed and established

legal and parliamentary process, Mr. Kundra said any constitutional amendment needs broad political consensus, consultation, and parliamentary consideration. He stressed that the process would move forward through dialogue and consensus and that no framework would be imposed on Ladakh without due consultation with stakeholders.

LAB, KDA disappointed

The members of LAB and KDA said they were “disappointed” with the talks, stating that the UT administration under L-G Vinai Saxena and the Union Home Ministry were not on the same page.

Cherring Dorjay Lakruk of the LAB said that if the government officials wanted them to answer questions, they should have shared the agenda beforehand. “They are asking us what will be the name of the elected body, what will be the CM called? They should have sent the agenda in advance. We cannot answer these questions in-

stantly, they involve legal questions,” he said.

Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, part of the LAB delegation that met Ministry officials on September 9, said that “no concrete progress” has been made on their key demands and cautioned that protests would resume if assurances were not provided within a week.

He added that the meeting was a “waste of time and money” and that the government should not compel them to protest.

“We spend our own money and come to Delhi, then we go back without a concrete outcome. Money and time is (sic) wasted. In 2020, when they needed us before the hill council elections there, the government sent a chartered aircraft for our leaders and asked (for) their help to not boycott the elections and help them win. They have made all efforts to drive wedges between the communities and regions and want to tire out the leaders, we are not giving up,” Mr. Wangchuk said.

CJP protest: SC seeks reply on closure of Metro stations

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought a response from the Centre on a petition questioning the closure of 17 Delhi Metro stations during the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protests held in Central Delhi over the NEET-UG 2026 question paper leaks.

The agitation had ultimately led to the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Education Minister.

A three-judge Bench headed by the Chief Justice of India Surya Kant issued notice to the respondents, Union and Delhi governments, the Delhi Police and the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation on the petition filed by Sparsh Kant Nayak, a resident of the national capital.

The court initially pointed out that the role of judicial review in the subject matter was limited as the issue of maintaining law and order came within the domain of the Executive.

The court, however, agreed to hear the respondents on whether the exercise of powers were within reasonable limits and in public interest.

SC declines relief to judicial officer over ‘outburst’ in HC

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday said a judicial officer raising his voice at judges in court amounted to “gross indiscipline”, while declining to stay criminal contempt proceedings against a senior Maharashtra judicial officer accused of an “outrageous” and “unpardonable” outburst in a packed courtroom.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta was hearing a plea by Dilip S. Ghumare, Secretary and Senior Legal Adviser in Maharashtra's Department of Law and Judiciary, challenging the Bombay High Court's September 1 order initiating contempt proceedings against him. “A judicial officer cannot shout against the judges in a court... He should repent for his words. This is gross indiscipline. Even a senior bureaucrat does not dare to



raise his voice in the court,” it observed.

The contempt proceedings stem from an incident in which Mr. Ghumare allegedly raised his voice in the courtroom and blamed the High Court administration for vacant judicial posts. The High Court had said that the officer's “unwarranted outburst” and “aggressive demeanour” amounted to “contempt *ex facie*” under the Contempt of Courts Act, 1971.

On Thursday, senior advocate Vikas Singh, appearing for Mr. Ghumare, sought a stay on the contempt proceedings, point-

ing out that his client had already tendered an apology and subsequently sought voluntary retirement. Mr. Singh told the Bench that Mr. Ghumare was required to serve a three-month notice period and had since been posted nearly 1,000 km away in a Naxalite-affected region.

The Bench, however, declined to stay the contempt proceedings, but restrained the High Court from passing a final order. It also issued notice on the officer's plea and listed the matter for September 28.

“Our advice to you is that you should go back to the High Court and seek an unconditional apology. Let the High Court consider your request,” it said.

The controversy arose during the hearing of a public interest litigation filed in 2013 by activist Vihar Durve concerning the creation and filling of posts in fast-track courts dealing with offences against women and minor girls.

Delhi HC says no to Phogat's participation in trials on Sept. 14

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Thursday refused to allow wrestler Vinesh Phogat to participate in the women's selection trials for the 2026 Senior World Championships.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, in a late-night interim order, said that at this stage, the court was not inclined to grant an interim exemption from the eligibility criteria to allow the petitioner to participate in the selection trials on September 14.

Criteria applies to all

“To reiterate, the criteria prescribed under the circular dated September 7, 2026 apply uniformly to all athletes. An athlete who has not participated in the prescribed competitions, for whatever reason, would not fall within the eligibility categories specified by respondent no. 1



Vinesh Phogat

(WFI),” the court said.

The High Court passed the order while dismissing an application by Ms. Phogat, who has returned from maternity leave, seeking permission to participate in the selection trials.

It said Ms. Phogat's circumstances relating to pregnancy, childbirth and postpartum recovery would require consideration while examining the validity of the policy. However, that does not, at the interim stage, by itself entitle her to a direction permitting her to participate contrary to the eligibility criteria, it added.

Focus on cooperation over confrontation in space: PM

Hemanth C.S.
PARIS

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has emphasised the need for countries to explore, innovate, and protect space together. He was delivering a speech through video-conferencing on the second day of the International Space Summit in Paris on Thursday.

He invited France and the world to be co-travellers in India's next space frontier. “Let the space summit in Paris send a clear message: We will explore together, innovate together, and protect space together, for all humanity, and for generations to come.”

The Prime Minister said that while orbits have become more crowded, technologies more powerful, and with more actors in the space domain, the focus should be on cooperation over confrontation, sustainability over short-term



Narendra Modi

gain, and inclusion over exclusion.

“We support a safe, secure, peaceful, and sustainable space domain anchored in international law, dialogue, and multilateral cooperation,” he said.

Mr. Modi highlighted the cost-effective missions of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) and its capabilities to serve farmers and fishermen, weather forecasting, disaster management, and navigation.

“More than 430 satellites from 34 countries have travelled to space aboard Indian rockets. IS-

RO's technologies and partnerships serve not only India, but the wider world,” he said. He cited the Chandrayaan-3 and Aditya-L1 missions, and the visit of an Indian astronaut to the International Space Station in 2025.

“Looking ahead, we aim to establish an Indian space station by 2035, and send an Indian to the moon by 2040. In all these efforts, our guiding principle has been clear: the benefits must reach all humanity. Alongside ISRO, India's private space sector is also surging in a big way,” he said.

During the summit, many French companies such as RIDEI, Safran Space, and U-Space signed several contracts with Indian companies such as TakeMeToSpace, Dhruva Space, and AXISCADES, respectively.

(This reporter is in Paris at the invitation of France's Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs to cover the International Space Summit)

THE CROSSWORD+14896

(set by Crossant)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY

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ACROSS

1. Begin with a bit of Turkish coffee (hot, not cold) (3,3)

4. Short stories about love — new collection withdrawn (6)

9. SRH's opening attack is superior (4)

10. Felt sceptical initially about anything learnt without formal training (4-6)

11. Office in Middle East country? Trouble all around (6)

DOWN

1. It seems Paul Ryan regularly makes Japanese dish (7)

2. Dog with head covered is bald perhaps (5)

3. Narrow passage in new flat is unusable to begin with (7)

5. Work to get money, having ultimately no alternative (6)

6. Landing in Spooner's urban community in Netherlands (5,4)

7. Power now controlled by extremely sententious figures (7)

8. Obligations about accepting American laws primarily for international expansion of trade (13)

14. Bias of Indian doctor getting a cut? (9)

16. View of European — definitely powerful (7)

18. Kind of flow seen in rising wild river (7)

19. What photographer may do to film progress? (7)

20. Love “Emotional Rescue” sung originally by Rolling Stones (6)

23. Worth fighting for project (5)

SUDOKU

4		5						
	8		3					1
		3	8	4				5
		4			6			
2			5		4			8
			9			7		
5				9	2	1		
1					8		7	
						6		2

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle

B	B	B	A	O	M	A	I
F	E	L	L	O	N	M	A
F	A	F	E	R	T	E	S
S	N	O	W	G	I	L	L
S	U	N	S	E	T	U	T
S	U	N	S	E	T	U	T
A	D	O	R	E	R	S	R
A	S	C	E	N	D	E	D
A	S	C	E	N	D	E	D
G	O	L	F	C	O	U	R
I	H	O	P	E	S	S	E
N	D	T	S	M	E	S	S

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

6	3	8	5	2	7	4	9	1
5	7	2	4	9	1	8	6	3
9	4	1	6	3	8	7	2	5
4	6	7	1	5	2	3	8	9
2	8	3	9	4	6	1	5	7
1	9	5	7	8	3	6	4	2
3	5	9	8	1	4	2	7	6
7	2	4	3	6	9	5	1	8
8	1	6	2	7	5	9	3	4

FAITH

Four paths to reach God

The two important paths of devotion are *Thothiram* and *Sasthiram*. *Thothiram* represents emotional and heartfelt devotion, while *Sasthiram* represents philosophical and intellectual understanding. Though their approaches differ, both lead the soul towards the same divine truth, said Lanka Sri Jeyaraj in a discourse.

Saiva Siddhanta explains four paths to reach God: *Chariya*, *Kriya*, *Yoga*, and *Jnana*. *Chariya* is external service and worship; *Kriya* connects external worship with inner devotion; *Yoga* is inward worship; and *Jnana* is the highest state of spiritual realisation. Appar, Sambandar, Sundarar and Manikkavasakar are traditionally associated with these four paths respectively.

Manikkavasakar represents the path of Jnana. In Thiruvagasam, he expresses his struggle between worldly attachments and his longing for Shiva. Though God comes to him with compassion and calls him, he feels unable to leave worldly life completely. Later, realising the greatness of the divine opportunity he had failed to embrace, he cries out in longing, regret and surrender.

That cry of the soul is Thiruvagasam – the longing to leave worldly bondage and become completely one with God. Manikkavasakar repeatedly expresses that human beings are trapped by ego, desire, attachment, karma and ignorance, and that they cannot free themselves by intellect alone. Liberation comes when Shiva's grace awakens the heart.

Manikkavasakar often speaks like a helpless child calling to a compassionate parent: “I have many faults, yet do not abandon me.”

CM

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HEALTH

Protein: reel, reality and what constitutes a wholesome meal

From recommending adding fish and chicken into the diet, to protein shakes, and lately a ‘Profee’ (protein and coffee), the online space has become a hyperactive protein-pushing zone; experts and doctors stress the need to seek medical guidance and make wholesome food choices without falling prey to trends

Ramya Kannan

In the past, a ‘healthy plate’ was the single prominent determinant of what constitutes healthy eating. Things, however, are far more complex today, as awareness grows about each meal, micro meals, snacks and what must comprise each such unit.

Even as, on one side, awareness about packaging and labels on packaged foods grows with the new FSSAI (Food Safety and Standards Authority of India) mandates, on the dark side, online/social media continue to influence food fads and generalised opinion gets packaged as expert advice. The flavour of a few seasons now, seems to be protein.

India is asking the wrong question about protein, the Physicians Association for Nutrition, India (PAN-India) said in a White Paper, issued in the context of the National Nutrition Week between September 1 and 7.

“Protein has become one of the most talked-about and most misunderstood topics in nutrition. Conversations are dominated by grams, “complete vs incomplete” labels, and high-protein product marketing. These measures are useful, but none of them alone tells you whether someone’s diet is actually healthy or adequate,” the paper says.

The treatise starts by contesting a basic principle: The conventional idea that animal protein is “complete” and plant protein is “incomplete” is oversimplification. Plant foods too contain all the essential amino acids the body needs; the amounts of each just vary by food. Within a varied diet with enough calories, the body gets what it needs across the day; you do not need to combine specific foods at every single meal, the nutritionists argue.

Push for protein

At the heart of the concern is excessive influence wielded on social media that pushes the protein narrative and sits in judgment over those not calibrating their protein per meal or per day. From recommending adding fish and chicken, to protein shakes and even, lately a ‘Profee’ (protein and coffee) the online space has become a hyperactive protein-pushing zone. Algorithms aggressively push recommendations and create fresh anxiety over whether one is getting enough protein or not.

Meenakshi Bajaj, dietician, Tamil Nadu Government Multi Super Speciality Hospital, says: “Unfortunately, social media content is available anytime and everywhere, just a swipe away. As a result, it often appears to have more influence than qualified professionals or evidence-based medicine. It is unfortunate that patients, regardless of age or education, can fall prey to food fads. Content shared by influencers, gym trainers, people with large followings, and unqualified health enthusiasts are being followed without checking the source, credentials, or scientific basis.”

She adds: “Just yesterday, I met a qualified professional undergoing dialysis who had read on social media that people



Behind the fad: People looking at burgers with extra protein options at a restaurant in Bengaluru. Protein has become one of the most talked-about and most misunderstood topics in nutrition. REUTERS

on dialysis require high protein. While that is correct, the post did not explain appropriate protein sources. He was consuming three to four whole eggs daily, along with 17 to 20 almonds and walnuts, which contributed to very high potassium and phosphorus levels that could be life-threatening. Had he consulted a qualified dietitian, she would have explained suitable food sources and cooking methods to control potassium and phosphorus while still meeting his protein needs.”

Another reason why protein has occupied centre stage is the growing use of GLP-1 antagonists, used widely for weight loss. Those on these drugs, are advised to watch muscle loss, a side effect of the process of losing weight. Protein is also said to assist with satiety in managing hunger. During any rapid weight loss process, protein may be burned for energy instead of serving the traditional function of tissue maintenance and repair.

The White Paper –Rethinking Protein in Plant-Based Diets – argues that protein should be understood within the context of a person’s complete diet rather than reduced to grams, amino-acid scores or marketing claims.

As per the Indian Council for Medical Research - National Institute of Nutrition recommendations, a healthy Indian adult must have approximately 0.83 grams of protein per kilogram of body weight daily, making it about 50 grams of protein for a 60-kg adult. This is the generalised norm, however, children in their growth phase, breastfeeding women, sportspersons and older adults might require more protein, the quantity going up to 2 grams per kg per day.

Chennai-based health and fitness coach Priyadarshini Raju says, “I wouldn’t call consuming protein itself a fad, but yes, there is a great deal of hype around protein right now. You don’t need to have protein written on the package of

A healthy Indian adult must have approximately 0.83 grams of protein per kilogram of body weight daily, according to ICMR recommendations

everything that you find in the aisle of a supermarket. However, for our population, a meal is extremely carbohydrate dominant. Just rice, chapati, idlis, dosas.”

For clients, her advise is to add a small amount of protein to each meal, as also fibre. But what kind of protein? “Breakfast can be as simple as besan or oats, or if you’re having dosa, just add a little paneer or tofu to it, if you are a vegetarian. Similarly, for lunch, add the same, or fish or chicken. The meal doesn’t have to be protein dominant but yes, there should be a little protein along with your carbs and fibre; fats, anyway, we get enough of in our traditional diets.”

Plant vs animal proteins

The paper pitches a similar angle: “In a varied diet with adequate calories, people generally do not need to combine specific proteins at every meal. Traditional combinations such as rice and dal, roti and chana, or idli and sambar are useful, but the more important issue is eating sufficient quantities of protein-rich foods,” also challenges the familiar claim that animal proteins are “complete” while plant proteins are “incomplete”.

Almost all plant foods contain all nine essential amino acids; there is a difference of course, and it lies in their relative proportions. It goes on to recommend prioritising pulses, beans, lentils, soy foods, nuts, seeds and whole grains, as they provide protein along with good fibre, unsaturated fats, vitamins, minerals and beneficial plant compounds.

PAN-India also addresses another elephant in the room: Supplements.

While arguing that protein supplements are not routinely necessary for healthy adults, they might have a role to play in helping athletes, older people with poor appetite, individuals on GLP-1 medications, or those recovering from illness. Ms. Priyadarshini agrees. “As far as supplements, I might recommend them to people who do are reluctant to bring any protein in their diet, especially vegetarians who have just a carb-loaded diet. Otherwise, I think as long as you’re able to fit in whole foods into your diet, you will be good. That is the best way.” Her vote is for raising awareness of protein consumption and making wholesome food choices.

Dr. Bajaj says: “A diversified, wholesome diet especially one with a high dietary diversity score, age-appropriate portion sizes, and foods that are local, traditional, and seasonal rather than packaged or processed would be considered as an ideal prescription for good health.” She explains that the core principles of nutrition prescription are adequacy, individualisation, and avoiding excess. “Therefore, a therapeutic nutrition plan should be guided by ABCDE: anthropometric measures, biochemical parameters, clinical signs and symptoms, dietary assessment, and exercise type, frequency, and intensity. It must also account for age, gender, medical and surgical history, drug-nutrient interactions, food allergies or intolerances, and economic status,” she adds. Food, ergo, is a complex business, best not left in the hands of social media influence.

“Protein should not be viewed only as a number on a food label. It is an essential macronutrient that supports growth, development, digestion, immunity, healing, and muscle protein synthesis, especially when combined with resistance training,” Dr. Bajaj notes.

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THE GIST

The White Paper — Rethinking Protein in Plant-Based Diets — argues that protein should be understood within the context of a person’s complete diet rather than reduced to grams, amino-acid scores or marketing claims

The paper says, “In a varied diet with adequate calories, people generally do not need to combine specific proteins at every meal. Traditional combinations such as rice and dal, roti and chana, or idli and sambar are useful, but the more important issue is eating sufficient quantities of protein-rich foods.”

A diversified, wholesome diet especially one with a high dietary diversity score, age-appropriate portion sizes, and foods that are local, traditional, and seasonal rather than packaged or processed would be considered as an ideal prescription for good health, say doctors

What happens when AI becomes first confidant in a mental health crisis

Athira Elssa Johnson

For some people, particularly youngsters, an AI chatbot is becoming the first place they turn to when they are distressed. It has its advantages: it is available at any hour, does not appear to judge them and can respond instantly. But when conversations involve thoughts of suicide, the limits of this interaction become consequential. Every conversation with an AI chatbot may not be harmful, but an apparently empathetic response could reinforce hopelessness, prolong rumination, or delay professional help in some people already at risk, say experts.

AI use for mental health support is now common. A U.S. survey of 1,009 people aged 12 to 21, published in JAMA Pediatrics found that 19.2% had used AI chatbots for mental health advice in 2025. Nearly 43% of these users did so at least monthly, while 5.8% used them daily or almost daily. Nearly two-thirds had not told anyone about this.

Another analysis of more than 6,20,000 publicly available ChatGPT conversations found that 4.9% could



Changing times: For some people, particularly youngsters, an AI chatbot is becoming the first place they turn to when they are distressed. ISTOCKPHOTO

be classified broadly as involving mental health, although only 0.21% met a stricter definition involving an identifiable person explicitly seeking mental health help.

Studies have also found that chatbots are generally better at recognising very low- and very high-risk scenarios, but struggle to distinguish between intermediate levels of suicide risk.

This is particularly concerning for psychiatrists, as suicidal distress is rarely expressed in a single, explicit statement and often emerges through a combination of subtle or changing cues.

‘Not always direct’

“Suicidal distress is not always direct; people may hint, use humour or gradually disclose their thoughts,”

said Mithun Prasad, consultant, psychiatry, SIMS Hospital, Chennai. Keyword recognition alone, he said, is therefore inadequate; the context and consistency of a conversation matter.

Sabaresh Pandiyan, consultant, psychiatry, Rela Hospital, Chennai, pointed to another issue: the ‘internal loop’, particularly among younger users, who may derive comfort from the empathetic part of an AI response, while ignoring advice to seek professional help. Repeated reassurance can also make suicidal thinking seem less urgent. “Talking about suicide or venting about suicide is not the problem, reinforcing hopelessness is,” he said.

Nithya M., consultant psychiatrist, Apollo Speciality Hospitals, Vanagaram, Chennai, emphasised that AI could amplify existing distress, prolong rumination or substitute validation for intervention.

In clinical practice, psychiatrists see patients use AI to discuss relationships, workplace problems and other personal concerns before speaking to family or friends. Dr. Pandiyan said around 60-70% of

patients in his setting discuss such matters with AI first. For some, this may help them recognise a problem and seek care earlier. Others may spend months trying to manage difficulties themselves before consulting a professional.

Dr. Nithya said warning signs can include patients quoting AI responses verbatim, withdrawing from human confidants, resisting professional help or developing a rigid view of themselves or their relationships based on chatbot responses.

Not a substitute for care

There may be limited situations in which patients use AI alongside clinical care. Dr. Prasad said some patients use chatbots between appointments to record medication effects or organise their thoughts, and later bring a summary to their psychiatrist. This can provide the clinician with information about what happened between consultations. But such use does not make AI a substitute for psychiatric assessment. A chatbot does not have access to a person’s psychiatric history, personality, psychological

defences, adverse life experiences, protective factors or current mental state. It may validate an emotion without recognising when urgent assessment is needed. This is particularly concerning when a person has psychosis, mania or distorted beliefs.

Psychiatrists call for mandatory safety audits, independent clinical assessments and clearer liability frameworks. Companies should be required to investigate and report serious safety incidents. Public education should also explain where AI is and is not appropriate.

Experts add that any response must also address the stigma that prevents people from seeking mental healthcare. Families and communities need to create safer spaces for people to talk about distress and seek help.

When a person is in a mental health crisis, experts said, the priority should remain timely human assessment and support. AI cannot take the place of that care. (Those in distress can seek help by contacting: ICALL 91529 87821)

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Rude lessons

India should learn from Canada and be wary of deals with the U.S.

The U.S.-Canada trade dispute has a few sharp lessons for India. The two economies have been deeply economically integrated since at least 1965, when they established free trade in automobiles and their parts. This then widened into a full-fledged free trade agreement in 1989, which was expanded into the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) about five years later. The economic integration between the U.S. and Canada has steadily continued and, by all accounts, has worked well for both economies. The target for the much smaller Canadian economy was to achieve economies of scale by producing vast amounts of a few products. According to Nobel laureate Paul Krugman, Canada accounts for 70% of the oil refined in the American Midwest, and supplies 60% of the nation's aluminium. It also supplies nearly all the types of lumber used in U.S. residential construction. Yet, despite this long and fruitful trade partnership, their economic relationship has fallen to a new low. Canada pulled out of negotiations over a new tariff deal citing last-minute insertions by the U.S. side. The U.S. has made a similar allegation against Canada. Canada recently levied reciprocal tariffs on the U.S. of up to 50% as a reaction to the 50% tariffs that the U.S. has imposed on imports from Canada. From September 29, the U.S. will outright ban certain Canadian alcoholic spirits, some dairy goods, and motorcycles. Statements by U.S. President Donald Trump are hardly conciliatory in nature.

The first lesson for India lies here: if this is how the U.S. treats a next-door neighbour, alliance member, and long-standing trade partner, India should not take for granted any favourable treatment that it might receive from the U.S. The second lesson is that barrelling ahead with trade deals might not always be the best plan. Before Canada, Malaysia also backed out of a deal it had signed with the U.S. It argued that once the U.S.'s reciprocal tariff system was deemed illegal, the benefit from a trade deal no longer outweighed the costs of opening up to the U.S. Despite the success of its recent trade pacts, India should weigh the same pros and cons when it comes to the U.S., especially since a deal might not be the end of the tariff pressure. India has faced this before. Despite the February 2026 agreement of 18% tariffs on imports from India, the U.S. has forged ahead with its forced labour and excess capacity investigations that could see tariff levels exceed that limit. India has done well to insist that a deal will not be struck until its advantage over its competitors is clear. The third lesson is that this advantage can vanish even after a deal is struck.

Growth spurt

Alternative powertrains are now mainstream in automobiles

According to data released by the Federation of Automobile Dealers' Associations (FADA), total vehicle registrations in August have increased 17.5% year on year, recording the all-time highest volume for the month, and with alternative powertrains, i.e., CNG, electric, and hybrids, leading passenger vehicle sales for the first time. But upon a closer look, some confounding factors emerge that also warrant caution about the figures. First, July 2026 itself was a strong month, with the August numbers 6.4% lower, possibly due to the monsoon. Second, the number of vehicles retailed in rural areas grew 19.7% year on year over 15.1% in urban areas; passenger vehicles sales likewise increased 24.9% in rural areas versus 10.9% in urban areas. This could be due to rising disposable incomes and consistent state capital expenditure on semi-urban infrastructure. However, tractor sales have in the past indicated monsoon-related rural stress, and while their sales are virtually unchanged year on year, they declined 25% month on month. Together with two-wheelers and passenger vehicles selling well, the trend suggests that non-farm rural incomes and mobility could be strengthening more than capital spending linked to agriculture. Third, last year, the GST Council reduced taxes on small cars, motorcycles (up to 350 cc), three-wheelers, buses, and goods vehicles, so August 2025 sales growth dropped as buyers waited for the new rates from September. Fourth, while CNG, hybrid, and electric powertrains beat petrol/ethanol vehicle sales by 1.1 percentage points, most hybrid vehicles still burn petrol while CNG itself is a fossil fuel. So the lead taken by alternative powertrains is not synonymous with a lead of non-fossil-fuel vehicles.

That said, petrol vehicles falling behind is still notable; the data also show that between August 2024 and August 2026, CNG and electric powertrains contributed most of the surge, implying that Indians are switching to alternatives that are cheaper to run, in light of the West Asia conflict and, to a lesser degree, concerns over ethanol blending. Next, the move away from petrol is uneven: three-wheelers are predominantly electric while two-wheelers catch up, and passenger cars' powertrains continue to diversify. And electrification continues to reflect rising consumer demand as much as industrial policy. Finally, FADA also reported that, despite record sales, dealers are holding 38-40 days of inventory against the recommended 21. So while the petrol era is far from over, the Indian automotive industry has commenced the mass-market integration of alternative powertrains. But that said, only if September-November preserves the gains in alternative powertrains after the base effect disappears, and dealer inventories return to normal levels, can August 2026 be considered a historic moment.

When the September 11, 2001 terrorist attacks took place, the United States was at the pinnacle of its power. A decade earlier, its Cold War rival, the Soviet Union, had disintegrated. Russia was still struggling to emerge from the post-Soviet chaos while China remained a close economic partner of the U.S. In eastern Europe, Washington had successfully undertaken military interventions, while the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) had completed its first round of expansion into Russia's neighbourhood. The U.S. also maintained a formidable military presence in West Asia. Then came 9/11.

The U.S., then the world's sole superpower, was understandably angry and anguished. It launched "a global war on terrorism", with Taliban-run Afghanistan, which had hosted al-Qaeda, the perpetrators of the 9/11 attacks, as its first target. But the war that then U.S. President George W. Bush launched went far beyond the remit of a fight against terrorism. Twenty-five years later, the U.S. remains bogged down in West Asia, its rivals are more assertive elsewhere, while the threat of terrorism has become more dispersed across West and South Asia and Africa.

Even though it was conceived as a transborder fight against terrorist organisations, primarily al-Qaeda, the war eventually evolved into a series of regime-change wars, driven by the goal of reshaping Afghanistan, West Asia and North Africa in accordance with American interests and worldview. Mr. Bush and his neoconservative allies believed that a "deficit of democracy" bred terrorism, and hence, the spread of democracy became a theoretical imperative of the war on terror. In Afghanistan, U.S. forces toppled the Taliban regime and established a new state – the Islamic Republic. The war forced al-Qaeda to disperse into autonomous cells and retreat, but it did not defeat the organisation.

Three consequences

In less than two years, the U.S. invaded Iraq. Besides the disastrous humanitarian cost of the war, the invasion had three lasting consequences. First, it diverted U.S. attention from Afghanistan and al-Qaeda, giving the Taliban space to regroup and lay the foundations for an insurgency that would eventually defeat the U.S. – 20 years after the 9/11 attacks.

Second, the destruction of the state of Iraq and the chaos that followed offered a new haven for al-Qaeda, which was also seeking to regroup. Before 9/11, Afghanistan had hosted Osama bin Laden's al-Qaeda. After the Iraq war, Abu Musab al-Zarqawi built the deadliest branch of the jihadist organisation in Iraq. The al-Qaeda in Iraq (AQI) would outlive Zarqawi, who was killed in a U.S. airstrike in 2006, and transform itself into the deadly Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS) in



Stanly Johny

Twenty-five years after 9/11, America's war on terror has also altered its strategic position worldwide

the early 2010s, after Syria, too, plunged into civil war.

Third, the collapse of the Saddam regime in Iraq removed a historical buffer between Iran and the U.S.-backed Persian Gulf monarchies. Saddam had fought Iran for eight years in the 1980s. True, he had later become an outcast in the U.S.-Sunni axis, but he remained a staunch enemy of Tehran. After Saddam fell, Iraq's Shia movements, which had deep historical ties with Tehran but had been suppressed under Saddam, emerged as the new centres of power in Baghdad. Iran steadily expanded its influence in Iraq, strengthening its regional position while also trapping the U.S. in the morass of Iraq.

The regime-change wars did not end with Iraq. In 2011, amid the Arab Spring protests, NATO launched an extensive bombing campaign in Libya aimed at "protecting the Libyan people" from Muammar Qaddafi's forces. The war, which then U.S. President Barack Obama later said he had "led from behind", brought down the Qaddafi regime but effectively destabilised Libya, once one of the most stable states in Africa. The collapse of the Libyan state opened the floodgates to terrorism across Africa, as weapons were smuggled across borders and fell into the hands of various militias and terrorist groups. Over the past 15 years, jihadist groups have spread their influence across the Sahel, while western influence has continued to diminish on the continent.

Cutting the losses, geopolitical chain effects

By the time Mr. Obama had left the White House, war weariness had set in across Washington. Iraq remained unstable, with growing Iranian influence. In Afghanistan, the Taliban were gaining strength with each passing day, putting American troops under enormous pressure. Libya was divided between rival governments and armed militias. In Syria, a Russian military intervention seemed to have turned the tide, though briefly, in favour of the Assad regime. While the U.S. was struggling to manage its wars in Afghanistan, West Asia and North Africa, China, America's key systemic rival, continued to rise economically and militarily. Having become bogged down in a strategic maze, the U.S. started cutting its losses and repositioning itself across the wider region.

The first move was to accept the fact that the U.S. had lost the war in Afghanistan, the first of its post-9/11 regime-change wars. Donald Trump's first administration began direct talks with the Taliban, and in February 2020, the U.S. signed an agreement with the Islamist insurgency, committing to withdraw American troops from Afghanistan. On August 15, 2021, two weeks ahead of the deadline, the Taliban entered Kabul.

The paradox of the post-9/11 era is that

America emerged from the Cold War as the world's unrivalled power, but its attempts to consolidate that primacy through military interventions gradually eroded the very strategic freedom that unipolarity had given it. Take the case of the U.S. withdrawal from Afghanistan. The U.S. saw the withdrawal as the swallowing of an inevitable bitter pill: Washington needed to trim its strategic overreach and prepare for the looming contest with China. But two developments since the withdrawal have erected obstacles to America's strategic repositioning.

First, the U.S. pullback from Afghanistan was interpreted as a sign of weakness by its rivals, particularly Russia, which had long sought to alter the post-Soviet security architecture in its rimland. Call it a geopolitical butterfly effect: in February 2022, less than a year after America's withdrawal from Afghanistan, Russia invaded Ukraine, testing the U.S. commitment to Europe.

Second, the October 7, 2023 Hamas attack on Israel shook the whole of West Asia. A furious

Israel announced its own "war on terror", launching a full-scale attack on Palestinians in Gaza and extending it into a mini-regional war in West Asia, setting off a chain of developments that led to the February 2026 U.S.-Israeli bombing of Iran. America's failure to learn the lessons of its failed regime-change wars, its inability to strategically decouple itself from Israel, and its hubris, coupled with a refusal to

accept the reality that the world has changed, have all contributed to this folly. The American-Israel axis sought to topple the Islamic Republic and reshape the region. But the war has trapped the U.S. in another quicksand in West Asia.

The changing global order

So, 25 years after the 9/11 attacks, terrorist groups have not only survived the war on terror but have also evolved into localised tentacles of a transnational jihadist project spanning multiple geographies. Despite America's commitment to Europe through NATO, there is a widening chasm in the transatlantic alliance. As traditional U.S. allies grow increasingly frustrated with Washington's newfound transactionalism, Israel, America's closest ally in West Asia, is dragging Washington deeper into a regional vortex. While the U.S. remains bogged down in West Asia, China has risen as the second pole of an increasingly fluid multipolar order, while Russia is violently challenging the U.S.-led security architecture in Europe. The U.S., as its ill-conceived Iran war would suggest, continues to act like a unilateral hegemon. But its unilateralism is increasingly at odds with the emerging realities of the post-unipolar world.

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The global war on terror, an empowered Iran

As West Asia remains mired in conflict, it is worth examining how the United States-led global war on terror inadvertently emboldened Iran, elevating it to a regional power that is now capable of confronting the U.S. in the ongoing conflict.

Prior to 2001, Iran faced strategic containment from two hostile regimes: the Taliban in Afghanistan and Saddam Hussein's Iraq. U.S. invasions toppled both governments, eliminating Iran's most dangerous neighbours. The new governments in both countries proved friendlier to Tehran. In Iraq, the fall of the Sunni regime led to a Shia-led government with deep ties to Iran, transforming an enemy into a strategic partner. According to analysts, Iran had surpassed the U.S. as the most influential power in Iraq, significantly improving its strategic position.

Sectarianism was the fuel

The invasions of Afghanistan and Iraq created a chaotic environment in the region that fuelled sectarian conflicts centred on the Shia-Sunni divide. These developments provided fertile ground for the emergence of terrorist groups such as al-Qaeda in Iraq, which later evolved into the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS). Regional powers took sides – Iran bolstered Shia militias in Iraq, while Saudi Arabia supported Sunni extremists. This sub-conventional proxy warfare entrenched Iran as a regional power broker, contrary to the overarching U.S. objective of isolating Iran.

ISIS, being ideologically anti-Shia, posed an unprecedented threat to Iran. This pushed Iran to become a central actor in the anti-ISIS coalition, deploying military advisers and mobilising allies across the region.

Iran consolidated its influence by becoming a key counter-terrorism player, exploiting power vacuums and using the crisis to strengthen its



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America's post-9/11 wars created strategic openings that Iran exploited

diplomatic position. Though the emergence of a shared enemy opened a narrow window for dialogue with the U.S., no synchronisation materialised, as President George W. Bush had famously labelled Iran part of the 'Axis of Evil' in his 2002 State of the Union address, alongside Iraq and North Korea, citing their pursuit of weapons of mass destruction and support for terrorism.

The role of the 'Axis of Resistance'

However, from Iran's point of view, what mattered was the "Axis of Resistance" (the Axis) – a political, military, and social network linking Iran, Iraq, Syria, Lebanon, and Palestine. It was designed as a "ring of fire" around Israel, serving as a form of forward defence for Iran. In addition, Iran gained several buffer zones in Iraq, Lebanon, Syria, and Yemen through key Axis members such as Hezbollah, Hamas, the Houthis, and Shia militias in Iraq. The Axis contributed to the emergence of the "Shia Crescent", an arc of Iranian influence extending through Iraq, Syria, and Lebanon.

Iran gained international legitimacy for its military activities in Iraq and Syria. Groups such as Hezbollah became battle-hardened and politically entrenched. The Houthis in Yemen graduated from a local insurgent movement into a political insurgent group. In terms of military capabilities, Iran's primary focus was on the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), which controls the country's strategic assets and specialises in sub-conventional warfare, including the control of proxies. By comparison, Iran's conventional military received far less attention.

The U.S. withdrawal from Iraq and the Arab Spring in 2011 created vacuums that Iran was uniquely positioned to fill. Iran invested

significantly in the Axis to gain an asymmetric advantage over the U.S. and Israel, as matching them on conventional military metrics was a difficult proposition for Tehran.

The "Forever Wars" in West Asia drained American resources and attention, allowing Iran to expand its influence unimpeded while reinforcing its hardline posture. The rise of ISIS paradoxically benefited Iran, which became one of the first and most critical military supporters of the Iraqi government in its fight against the group. Iran deployed its elite Quds Force to coordinate Baghdad's defence, cementing its influence over Iraq's security apparatus. In Syria, defending the Assad regime protected Iran's only major state ally and helped consolidate its supply routes to Hezbollah in Lebanon.

The transformation of Iran

The global war on terror fundamentally transformed Iran from a contained state into a dominant regional power. By removing hostile regimes, creating power vacuums, and unintentionally strengthening Iran's alliance network,

U.S. actions produced outcomes diametrically opposed to their stated objectives.

The global war on terror enabled Tehran to project power in Afghanistan, Lebanon, Syria, and Yemen. As a result, Iran's role as a pivotal broker was cemented, with lasting consequences for West Asian geopolitics.

Having benefited from these developments, Iran increasingly invested in the Axis while rallying domestic support around nationalism rather than religion. Iran's current resilience against the U.S.-Israeli offensive in West Asia could be viewed as a manifestation of the strategic advantages flowing from the global war on terror.



LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Cash transfers, welfare

Unconditional cash transfers (September 7) can provide valuable support to women, particularly where household incomes are uncertain and unpaid care work remains largely unrecognised. However, welfare schemes should not become a source of political uncertainty for their beneficiaries. Governments should publish clear

eligibility criteria, provide simple grievance-redress mechanisms, and regularly review exclusion errors. Payments should also be accompanied by opportunities for employment, skill development, and access to essential services. This would make welfare less dependent on recurring cash assistance. At the same time, fiscal costs must

be assessed honestly, since resources are limited. The objective should be to combine immediate support with measures that improve household security and economic independence. Welfare is most effective when it strengthens citizens' choices rather than merely fostering dependence. **Abbharna Barathi,** Chennai

Seeking Gen Z online

Following the Cockroach Janta Party and Gen Z protests, the Prime Minister reportedly urged Ministers to engage more frequently with Gen Z through social media platforms. Soon, MPs – and increasingly, Ministers – began adopting Gen Z terminology and digital idioms. A more recent trend is even more revealing: AI-generated

"retro" images portraying political leaders as their younger selves in the 1980s. There is nothing wrong with politicians having a little fun on social media. But the trend raises a larger question: are they mistaking the medium for the message? The Election Commission of India cautioned political parties and candidates in October 2025 about the use of

AI-generated and synthetic content. That caution deserves attention as political communication embraces AI. Gen Z is unlikely to be won over merely because politicians adopt its language, platforms or nostalgia.

N. Nagarajan, Secunderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Should the use of Gen AI be banned among younger students in schools?



Lavina Jaswani

Founder of the Sprouts International School in Jaipur



Deepa Jacob

Class 5 teacher at the American International School in Chennai

PARLEY

Recently, New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani announced a one-year moratorium on most generative AI tools for public school students until Class 8 for the 2026-27 academic year. Officials argued that young children require human connection and independent problem-solving skills instead of relying on algorithms. India's policies on this issue are still evolving. So, should the use of Gen AI be banned among younger students in schools? Lavina Jaswani and Deepa Jacob discuss this question in a conversation moderated by Priscilla Jebaraj.

What kind of AI tools do you use and how do they benefit primary school children?

Lavina Jaswani: We have been using a number of AI-enabled tools to explain concepts to children; to offer personalised learning; and to help teachers create resources, from stories and worksheets to different types of assessments and quizzes. There are different apps we use, such as Kahoot! and Quizlets, to offer a gamified, interactive, and sensorial learning experience that keeps children engaged, rather than the traditional rote learning method.

However, the teacher still has to ask herself: what is my learning objective? What does a child need to understand? Where can the technology add value and is it truly beneficial and essential for the child? Keeping such questions in mind, AI tools can be effectively used in the classroom.

Deepa Jacob: In our school, technology is integrated seamlessly into our teaching and learning experience. Every child from kindergarten onwards has access to an iPad, which is kept at the school; they don't take them home. They have apps that might be able to assist them with learning such as Seesaw, which is a journal of their learning through which they can keep a record of things that they do, like published writing pieces, videos of science experiments, their reflection on their learning etc. You can even assign tasks on them.

Very recently, I discovered that Seesaw itself has an AI component. So, for example, we do a lot of work with reading fluency. The kids are given a grade-level passage. They do a cold read of it on day one and through the week they reread the passage along with the teacher, and learn to pronounce the words, the meaning of the words, and then finally on day five they record their reading again and they find that they've improved in their fluency and their accuracy. Recently, one of my colleagues found out that the recording feature has an AI component which transcribes what you've said and scores you based on your accuracy. This is really great because rather than the teacher having to listen to every child read, if an app can score your reading and tell you which words you



New frontier: India's first AI teacher 'Iris' interacts with students at a school, in Attingal, in Thiruvananthapuram, in 2024. PTI

are reading incorrectly, then you can practise those words alone. But it's AI, not a person, so it comes with its own flaws. For example, one of my students was reading a word with an Indian accent, and the app marked it wrong. The same thing happened to students using several other Asian accents. So, that's where I feel the human component is important. We need to be careful that we don't let AI take over our lives.

I also do not allow generative AI in my classroom. When I ask my children a question, or if they have a question, I will never ask them to Google it. Because the easiest way to kill a love for learning is to find a ready-made answer.

Educationists and philosophers in the field of education have talked about existing in the liminal space, which is that space where you struggle with a concept, that threshold between not knowing something and struggling with something and then finally learning it. I think that is a beautiful space to be in mentally and we need these as human beings. We need this time and space to reconfigure ourselves; time for ideas to incubate and grow. Relying on technology in that phase would be terrible. While technology should be used as a tool, it is easy to over-rely on technology and use it as a crutch. If you want to create human beings that make their own contribution in the world, I think there should be serious restrictions on the amount of AI used among kids.

One fear is that AI could harm a student's ability to think and learn for themselves – for instance, if they just enter their homework as a ChatGPT prompt, the AI does their homework for them. Is this a valid fear?

LJ: Yes, this is where we need to take a balanced position. AI can affect children's thinking abilities, but it depends on how we use it. There are two possibilities: one is when the child uses the AI, the AI gives the answer, the child copies it, submits it and moves on. Then we have a problem, as the child is not using his brain.



Children are much more tech savvy and even AI-savvy than they were a few years ago. So I don't think bans and restrictions are the solution. It is better to understand artificial intelligence and make our children aware of the pros and cons

LAVINA JASWANI

Instead, we need to guide the child on how to use it and that is where we need to put the restriction.

Suppose you are trying to teach fractions or some kind of problem-solving lesson. If the AI gives the answer, the child misses the struggle, the trial and error, the logical thinking, and the satisfaction of finally getting the answer.

So the rule in my classroom is that first, the child needs to think it, then write it and then lastly, ask the AI to verify the answer. They must try to solve it themselves, but if they can't, just as they may ask their parents or their teacher for help, they can ask AI too to provide assistance in the same way.

DJ: The problem is over-reliance. If you've been driving a manual car and then you shift to an automatic car, you're going to find it really hard to go back to driving manual, right? Similarly, I think you can become over-reliant on someone else doing the thinking for you or even synthesising ideas by just feeding them into an AI tool such as the Notebook LLM. The capacity of the human brain is immeasurable. There's so much study that has gone into how brains function, and their neuroplasticity. It would be a shame if we let it die. Especially in the primary and elementary years, where so much of growth is happening.

So while AI is a great tool, I think we should be very cautious in how it is used.

At the same time, I don't think a complete ban is the answer and a one-year moratorium may not be enough to think through, to plan, and to set up some guardrails around how AI should be used in education.

AI is now an integral part of basic search, of Google, of emails, and even in games. So students are using AI whenever they use the Internet at home. So why keep it out of class?

DJ: As educators, we don't really have control over what kids are exposed to at home, but the one place where we can still teach critical thinking skills is in the classroom. I think we have to preserve that as far as we can. Also, I think children these days are really good at spotting something that's AI-generated versus the real thing, and for many of them it is not cool anymore.

I feel like we, the older generation, are more

easily fooled when it comes to AI.

LJ: Children are much more tech savvy and even AI-savvy than they were a few years ago. So I don't think bans and restrictions are the solution. It is better to understand AI and make our children aware of the pros and cons.

Central and State governments are starting to commission pilot projects using AI tools in government schools and in rural areas where there is a shortage of quality teachers, in the hope that AI can bridge that gap. Could AI supplement or even replace teachers in some of these schools?

LJ: AI should not replace a teacher; it should extend the teacher. Especially in primary education, where children learn best through stories, activities, and conversations – moments that are very important to human relationships. That bond with the teacher is very important. So I would never want AI to become the teacher sitting in front of the children. I see AI as a learning assistant.

DJ: My first job was in a village school and there were times I wished I had more resources and more tools, especially to translate more content and make it accessible. But I agree that you cannot completely do away with teachers just because knowledge can be found anywhere. But if you think of schools as not just knowledge centres, but wisdom centres where you learn from other human beings about how to become a good human, then you need teachers to be present, curating resources for the child.

How have you found AI helpful for teacher preparation and training?

DJ: Prep time is very limited so AI tools really help. If I input what I need to teach into Gemini, it helps me create slide decks that I can then present to the class, but again, we need to be careful because we have learnt through experience that AI can hallucinate and put out wrong information, so teachers do need to double check.

LJ: It can help teachers use different techniques in their classroom. Suppose I am teaching fractions in class and one child understands the concept immediately, but another child is still confused; traditionally, the second child may simply hear the same explanation again, but an AI tool can guide the teacher to teach fractions in a more visual and fun way by using a chocolate and dividing it up.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

Up close with Chinna Thambi: a privilege and a curse

The best part about being a journalist is getting access to places we will not be able to visit otherwise. But that access can, at times, leave us uneasy

Akila Kannadasan

I had heard so much about him and his boyish charm that when it was time for me to finally meet him, I felt jittery. During the jeep ride to his temporary home, my mind kept replaying things people had said about him: his little quirks, his love for food, and his intelligence.

I am talking about Chinna Thambi, the wild elephant that was tranquillised, captured, and tamed to become a camp elephant in Tamil Nadu's Anamalai Tiger Reserve (ATR) in 2019.

Chinna Thambi was a crop raider during his carefree days in the Thadagam valley in the outskirts of Coimbatore. He would enter human habitation with the innocence and curiosity expected of a young elephant bull – he was 25 when he was caught – and eventually got used to the villages on the fringes of the forest.

I had followed the elephant's story with interest. After he was caught and sent to the Varagaliyar camp in ATR, I travelled there to meet him. I was writing a piece on the taming of Chinna Thambi.

To me, the best part about being a journalist is gaining access to places that I cannot even dream of visiting otherwise. The Varagaliyar elephant camp for instance, is not open to the public. Once I got the nod from Mr. V. Ganesan, the then Field Director of ATR, I joined him during an official visit to the camp one evening, an hour before dusk set in.

I will never forget the journey. The sturdy Forest Department jeep trundled along narrow trails that barely existed. Those mud roads were so untouched that I felt we were clearing foliage that had bent into our path much like how elephants move around forests.

For another feature on abandoned elephant calves, I got to observe the little ones and their antics from up close. They were taken to the Theppakadu camp in

Mudumalai Tiger Reserve after their rescue, kept far from the public eye in an open enclosure. I was allowed to go a little closer to see their mahouts take them for walks and feed them milk through tubes.

The skies opened up when I visited the same camp one afternoon for a story on mahouts and their bond with elephants. It was mealtime and the men were mixing cooked ragi, rice, horse gram, and salt into mammoth balls to be fed to the elephants. From where I stood, I could almost taste those chocolate-coloured balls. Had I been a regular tourist, I would have been standing far away, beyond a long wooden fence.

A journalist's access to fascinating people and places is a privilege like none other. This access allows us to approach a story with all our five senses.

Sometimes though, this can also lead to discomfort. For, not all of these experiences are those that we would look back on with fondness.

When I neared the camp where Chinna Thambi was kept, my enthusiasm was replaced by a sense of trepidation. I hopped off the jeep to notice the gigantic wooden enclosure in which he stood. I could see his tail from afar – the *kraal* (enclosed pen) was composed of wooden beams.

In that moment, I wanted nothing but to run away. I didn't want to meet Chinna Thambi. I was not ready to see him that way. When the Field Director glanced back at me, I knew I had to snap out of it. I didn't have a choice.

Chinna Thambi's mahout offered him large balls of ragi from outside. I took a step closer to the enclosure for a better look. It was the first time I was seeing a wild elephant from such close quarters. Then, he put out his trunk for food. I jerked back. The mahout said jokingly, "All he wants is food," adding, "He's almost broken; it's just a matter of a few days."

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PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Saline surplus



Workers load bags of salt onto a truck from the salt pans near Beeramgunta, Ongole, on September 9. Work on the salt pans usually ends with the coming of the rains in June, but with almost no rainfall due to El Niño, salt continues to be harvested. The price of salt has fallen from ₹400–₹500 per tonne last year to ₹100–₹120 this year. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 11, 1976

Eradication of smallpox

New Delhi, September 10: The Union Minister for Health and Family Planning, Dr. Karan Singh said on Thursday in a country like India with its vast magnitude of problems, public health programmes should be given equal weightage as the family planning programmes. Inaugurating the two-day All-India review meeting on smallpox programmes here, Dr.



Karan Singh said: "In our zeal to popularise family planning programme, which is no doubt necessary, we should not neglect the public health programmes." All such programmes have to be tackled simultaneously with equal zest, he added.

The review meeting on smallpox is being attended by all Directors of Health Services and Medical Officers in charge of smallpox eradication programmes in all States of the country. Regarding smallpox eradication, he said by next Independence Day, India should attain zero level in the disease.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 11, 1926

Germany's entry into league

As there was no issue dated September 11, 1926, from the issue dated September 10, 1926 – Geneva, September 9: The meeting of the British and Dominion delegates in Sir. A. Chamberlain's room at his hotel this morning discussed the question of the probable applicants for the 9 vacant non-permanent seats on the Council. It is understood that the Dominion representatives declared they were not prepared to press their claims for seats.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Emergency World Bank funds to be received by Kenya

400 in \$ million. Kenya is expected to receive about \$400 million in emergency financing from the World Bank within six weeks to help address risks including an Ebola outbreak in the region and El Niño-related disruptions, a source familiar with the matter said. REUTERS

Percentage increase in Equity MF inflows in August

19 in per cent. Equity mutual fund schemes attracted ₹29,329 crore in August, registering a highest net inflow in four months, as investors continued to favour mid- and small-cap funds. This inflow was nearly 19% higher than the ₹24,697 crore recorded in July. PTI

Persons killed after cargo ship catches fire in China's port

20 A cargo ship docked for repairs in a Chinese port caught fire, killing at least 20 people and leaving five others missing, Chinese state media reported Thursday. The ship was being repaired in the Beihai Shipbuilding Co. at the port of Qingdao, a major shipping hub. AP

Amount transferred to beneficiaries under 26 schemes in Haryana

1,890 in ₹ crore. Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday transferred ₹1,890.16 crore directly into the bank accounts of more than 50 lakh eligible beneficiaries under 26 different schemes through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT). PTI

People affected in 14 districts as floods wreak havoc in Bihar

43 in lakh. More than 43 lakh people have been affected by floods in 14 districts of Bihar, with several rivers flowing above the danger mark, officials said. Incessant rain in several parts has caused rivers and streams to overflow, they said. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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How should RUPPs be regulated?

Why do some RUPPs remain active despite poor compliance? How can their misuse be curbed? What can be done to improve transparency? Should RUPPs face a vote threshold for tax breaks? How can the EC act against non-serious parties?

EXPLAINER

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

A 'BBC News Hindi' investigation has revealed that six Registered Unrecognised Political Parties (RUPP), all based in Gujarat, had received donations of around ₹1,700 crores for the year 2023-24. This is higher than the total received by five nationally recognised political parties, except the BJP, for the same period, which stood at ₹1,480 crores.

What are registered parties?

Political parties are an association or body of individuals that can be formed by citizens. Section 29A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951 (RP Act) lays down the requirements for registration of a political party with the Election Commission (EC). After satisfactory scrutiny of the documents submitted, the EC registers a political party as a RUPP. The RUPPs enjoy the following benefits – (a) tax exemption for donations received under Section 12 of the Income Tax Act, 2025, (b) common symbol for contesting general elections to the Lok Sabha/State Assemblies, and (c) 20 'star campaigners' during election campaign. The RUPPs are required to maintain the details of individual donors above twenty thousand rupees in a financial year and submit them to the poll body every year. As per section 29C of the Representation of the People Act, failure to furnish these details will result in losing income tax exemption.

The RUPPs, under the Income Tax Act, 2025, are required to accept donations in excess of two thousand rupees only through cheque or bank transfers.

What are the issues?

As per the EC notification, India had more than 2,800 RUPPs as of July, but only around 750 contested the 2024 general elections. This has resulted in the moniker – 'letter pad parties' – for the rest of the RUPPs. The RP Act does not



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confer explicit powers on the EC to de-register a political party if it fails to contest elections, conduct inner-party elections, or lodge requisite returns. In the *Indian National Congress vs Institute of Social Welfare & Ors* (2002), the Supreme Court held that the EC does not have the power to de-register any political party under the RP Act. It may de-register only under exceptional circumstances, such as registration obtained by fraud, the political party ceasing to have allegiance to the Constitution, or being declared unlawful by the government. The EC periodically publishes the list of de-listed RUPPs. The October 2025 notification contains over 800 such parties.

However, the six RUPPs – Aam Janmat Party, Bharatiya National Janata Dal, Garib Kalyan Party, New India United Party, Satyawadi Rakshak Party and the Swatantrata Abhiviyakti Party – remain on the list of active RUPPs as per the EC notification in October 2025. This is because they managed to field a total of 15 candidates during the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. The Association for Democratic

Reforms periodically publishes reports on the status of submission of annual reports of RUPPs. In its July 2025 report, in which the annual reports of 2022-23 are analysed, it is stated that reports of only 26% of RUPPs are available in the public domain. Poor compliance with statutory requirements, coupled with a lack of transparency, results in these 'letter pad' parties being used as an opaque channel for tax evasion and money laundering.

What needs to be done?

The Law Commission, in its 255th report, had recommended amendments for de-registration of a political party if it fails to contest elections for ten consecutive years. The EC, in its memorandum for electoral reforms (2016), also suggested an amendment to the RP Act that would empower it to de-register a party. These are long-pending reforms that need to be carried out to empower the EC to act against non-serious parties, some of which are merely a façade for illegal financial transactions.

However, if parties contest elections

merely to fulfil a statutory requirement, they could continue to misuse their tax exemptions and be used for money laundering and other nefarious activities. In the present digital world, it is not difficult for the Income Tax Department and other enforcement agencies to monitor the transactions of such parties and take strict action against any wrongdoing. This would act as a deterrent against the misuse of the benefits and exemptions available to political parties. The EC had also suggested that tax exemptions be provided only for political parties that win seats in Lok Sabha or Legislative Assembly elections. This can be viewed as an undemocratic and extreme measure, as there are parties that consistently contest elections without electoral success. Instead, similar to the 1% vote threshold for allotting common symbols to RUPPs, a suitable vote percentage threshold may be stipulated by law for RUPPs to avail of tax exemptions on donations received. (Rangarajan R. is a former IAS officer. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

▼ Six Gujarat-based RUPPs received about ₹1,700 crore in donations in 2023-24, raising concerns over opaque political funding

▼ Weak statutory provisions and poor compliance allow many non-serious RUPPs to remain active and potentially misuse tax exemptions

▼ The EC needs stronger powers to de-register such parties, while a suitable vote threshold could determine eligibility for tax exemptions

Why are Volkswagen and JLR trimming their workforce?

European carmakers are falling behind their Chinese counterparts in the race to corner the EV market

G. R. Rajeev

The story so far:

The German carmaker Volkswagen and the British marquee brand Jaguar Land Rover (JLR) are shedding jobs – the former deciding to axe 50,000 positions and the Tata-owned brand 4,000. The latest cut will reduce Volkswagen's employee count by a lakh by the end of the decade, as the company had already reached agreements with employees since the end of 2024 to cut 50,000 jobs.

European carmakers have fallen behind Chinese manufacturers in the race to transition to electric vehicles and want to be shipshape in navigating the challenging terrain.

In July, BMW revealed its decision to cut its workforce by 8,000. Nifty homegrown brands are blocking Volkswagen's traffic in the lucrative Chinese market, and the company, under

its chief executive, Oliver Blume, is taking a hard look at its worldwide operations, especially in the German market.

How have the two carmakers reached a settlement to cut jobs?

By no means has it been a smooth drive for the two giants who thrived in the heyday of internal combustion engines. Volkswagen had to contend with its powerful union to get approval for what many say is the most eventful restructuring in its 89-year history.

Workers hold 10 seats in the decision-making supervisory Board of the company and shareholders, including the State of Lower Saxony, another 10. The job cuts were announced after a tense meeting of the Board.

"Volkswagen is simply not a corporation that operates solely according to capitalist rules. Because of its history, Volkswagen also belongs to us, the employees," Daniela Cavallo, top union representative, said, as quoted by

the *Wall Street Journal*.

Much of the money spent on building a plant at its Wolfsburg headquarters in the 1930s came from the earnings of the company's workers seized during Adolf Hitler's reign, and that gives a sense of ownership even to the present-day workforce.

The agreement stopped short of an announcement on closing down four factories at Emden, Hanover, Zwickau and Neckarsulm in Germany, deemed to have no future after 2030, when electrification is expected to stub out production of cars powered by internal combustion engines in Europe. The company has reset its targeted production to nine million vehicles a year, from 12 million before the COVID-19 pandemic and 10 million recently.

On the other hand, JLR, the cash cow of Tata Motors, is targeting £1.7 billion (around ₹28,000 crore) in savings through the job cuts, reports said. The cuts will largely target the white-collar

workforce, while direct manufacturing jobs will be protected.

The company will scale down its breakeven point to 3 lakh vehicles from 3.5 lakh, reducing annual sales by 14% to cover its cost base. This will make it fitter in a rapidly evolving global market due to rapid technological change, intense competition, and geopolitical uncertainty, JLR chief executive P.B. Balaji said.

Why are the two carmakers on the skids?

Volkswagen ruled Chinese roads for four decades till its growth engines started sputtering. The world's largest carmaker after Toyota was late to the EV race with fleet-footed Chinese carmakers, after dominating the market through a string of joint ventures. Even in Latin America and Africa, dominant markets of the German giant, Chinese carmakers are giving Volkswagen nightmares. In China, its sales skid by one-third of the 2019 figures, reports said.

There is no model blitz in taking on Chinese rivals pumped up by cheaper state-backed loans. The company lost out to manufacturers such as BYD and Geely owing to a perceived reluctance to take the wheel in the EV race.

For JLR, with the U.S. as its largest market but with no American production base, Donald Trump's tariffs have created potholes on the road to profits. The tariffs on exports to the U.S. from the U.K. range

from 10% to 15% for its models. It was China where its sales plummeted the most despite its electric-only reinvention.

How are the companies changing gears in India?

Volkswagen, which underwent a renaissance in India in recent years as Skoda Auto Volkswagen India Private Ltd., with models made for India, is looking for an active partner for its business. Volkswagen expects to sign a deal with a local partner in India this year, the chief executive officer of its Skoda brand, Klaus Zellmer, said in India, as the German group struggles to build scale in the world's third-largest car market, *Reuters* reported in August.

Skoda is in charge of the group's strategy in India, where Volkswagen is in talks on a joint venture with the JSW group, which has indicated it wants a majority stake. Mr. Zellmer said VW was in discussions with an unnamed partner and was confident of completing a deal this year.

JLR is a wholly owned subsidiary of Tata Motors, which acquired the iconic British luxury automaker in 2008. It clocked its best first-quarter retail sales for 2026-27 at 1,665 vehicles, an 11% year-on-year increase, in India. The India-U.K. free trade agreement is benefiting the company. JLR and Tata Motors opened a plant in Ranipet in Tamil Nadu in February 2026.

ECONOMIC NOTES

Why India must rethink the way it values skills, jobs and productive work

India risks a middle-income, low-productivity trap as weak job creation, stagnant wages and sluggish investment reinforce one another; escaping it requires better vocational education, wider diffusion of technology and useful knowledge, and greater social value for skilled work

Kalaiyarasan A.

India, celebrated as the world’s fastest-growing economy, has become the world’s fourth-largest economy, and is expected to be the next engine of global growth. Yet beneath these numbers lies a grim reality: India is drifting toward the middle-income trap, in which countries exhaust their gains from cheap labour and rapid catch-up and fail to transition to an innovation-driven, productivity-based economy. Weak job creation, stagnant wages, sluggish private investment, and low productivity are reinforcing one another, threatening to stall the country’s rise before it reaches high-income status. Many countries in the Global South are caught in this trap. India’s structural crisis is unique and more serious than not just a consequence of wars in West Asia disturbing its supply chain or premature automation from AI.

The signs of distress are visible in the youth protests across the country. Private investment remains sluggish, wage growth is stagnant, and household consumption is weak. Manufacturing has failed to generate enough jobs, while post-pandemic recovery has favoured large corporations and the digital economy, leaving the informal sector barely touched. Jobless growth emerges because productivity gains stay concentrated in narrow, capital- and skill-intensive enclaves that create little employment. This simultaneous rise of rising inequality and low productivity is a dangerous trap.

Two failing engines

Economists are typically divided in explaining this trap. Those trained in pro-market orthodoxy argue India needs another set of market reforms – no less than what occurred during the 1991 moment – more labour flexibility, agricultural reform, deregulation, and infrastructure investment. Those on the left and typically in the Keynesian mould argue that the economy suffers from weak aggregate demand and needs more public spending, redistribution and social protection. Both arguments hold a kernel of truth, but miss the larger point: India’s current situation stems not only from supply and demand constraints but from institutions shaped by social norms, which decide both how markets set incentives and prices, and how the State allocates resources and provides public goods.

It is no surprise, then, that both the State and the market operate suboptimally. Private capital, more freer from regulation than ever, does not do well on productivity and innovation. Its competitiveness comes from cutting costs rather than innovating. It couldn’t even absorb knowledge that comes with FDI. It couldn’t increase productivity that results from both inter-sectoral movements and innovation within sectors either. On the other hand, capital is heavily subsidised, lowering its relative price vis-à-vis labour in a labour-surplus economy. India’s innovation is skewed, with R&D spending at a paltry 0.65% of GDP, while technology adoption remains weak and far from spontaneous. Despite the government’s growing size, India’s capacity to intervene – even to provide basic services like health centres or schooling – remains among the lowest



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anywhere.

The Left-Right debate focuses on the size and quality of government expenditure, but the problem lies elsewhere. The same social norms that shape resource allocation also drive its inefficient use. For instance, India has historically underfunded mass education while subsidising higher education for elites, tilting spending toward the privileged. That same elite bias later drove the service-sector-heavy growth of post-reform India, letting upper castes monopolise better occupations while relegating low-productivity work to others.

Undervaluing useful skills

India’s social norms are distinctive: they decide how State and market function while producing durable inequality and legitimising it. Having long undermined mass education, India’s vocational training system remains poorly managed and chronically underfunded. Fewer than 3% of the workforce has any formal vocational education. Of roughly 14,000 ITIs offering about 25 lakh seats, actual intake is only about 48%, and even among graduates, the employment rate is just 63% – far below the 90%-plus seen in many other countries.

Societies set up institutions based on their interests and norms. Economists often take self-interest as central to economic motives. Yet social norms determine the kind of institutions that take shape, which in turn decide how individual efforts are channelised into productive activities. These institutions work as the taproot of entrepreneurial success. As this year’s Nobel Prize winner Joel Mokyr has argued, modern growth depends on the accumulation and diffusion of “useful knowledge,” the practical skills that enable societies to innovate, adapt and raise productivity.

For Mokyr, sustained growth rests on the coevolution of science, technology and the spread of useful knowledge,

something that failed to take strong root in India. India has historically privileged abstract education over vocational and technical knowledge. University degrees command prestige while technical courses training electricians, welders, machinists and carpenters do not. This hierarchy is not accidental. It reflects centuries of caste-based occupational stratification, where manual and artisanal work has been systematically undervalued despite its indispensable role in industrial development.

The result is a chronic shortage of skilled manufacturing workers even as millions of educated young Indians struggle to find decent jobs. Ironically, India’s Chief Economic Adviser, V Anantha Nageswaran, recently urged the youth to pursue trades such as welding and plumbing instead of chasing software jobs or MBAs.

But it won’t happen unless India changes its social valuation of skills. Take the marriage market: some skills and occupations carry a premium over others. These social valuations shape educational choices, occupational aspirations and ultimately the allocation of labour.

Data show a persistent and steady decline in the labour intensity of production technology across sectors. Even in traditionally labour-intensive sectors, the trend is likely to accelerate with the advent of AI. India therefore needs to recalibrate not just production and distribution, but also their valuation. Without changing the cultural valuation of skills and the way production itself is organised, India may fall into a low-income, low-productivity trap.

Diffusion of useful knowledge

Countries that escaped the middle-income trap – from South Korea to China – did not simply build factories but built institutions capable of creating and diffusing useful knowledge across domains. China’s interventions in education and health laid the foundation

for its later productive capacity. Its early state-led industrialisation was accompanied by massive investments in technical education, local manufacturing capability and technological learning. By contrast, countries such as Brazil, Argentina, Thailand and the Philippines, which failed to build or sustain such institutions, became stuck in the middle-income trap. Like India, large sections of their populations remain dependent on public transfers and handouts to secure the basic requirements of a prosperous existence.

As an alternative to this trap, Harvard Economist Dani Rodrik has recently proposed what he calls productivism – an approach that shifts attention from ex-post redistribution to creating productive employment. It calls for the dissemination of economic opportunity and differs from free market orthodoxy in giving the government an important role over the markets in shaping economic opportunities. It emphasises the real economy over finance, jobs over redistribution and production over consumption. A truly inclusive economy, according to him, gives people dignity and social recognition as productive members of society. It can happen not just by recalibrating the policy framework but by overhauling the institutional framework and changing the norms that underpin those institutions by moving beyond the matrix of state-market binaries.

For India, this means combining industrial policy with investments in vocational education. It also means restoring dignity to skilled manual work and creating institutions that spread technology beyond a handful of elite enclaves. Without transforming how the country values skills, builds productive capabilities, and expands access to good jobs, India risks being locked into a low-productivity economy.

(Kalaiyarasan A. is Associate Professor, Madras Institute of Development Studies)

THE DAILY QUIZ

Test your knowledge of the battle in which William Wallace, Andrew de Moray turned a narrow crossing on the River Forth into one of Scotland’s most consequential victories

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1

Which two Scottish commanders jointly led the forces at Stirling Bridge?

QUESTION 2

How many horsemen could reportedly cross the bridge abreast?

QUESTION 3

What type of Scottish formation played a crucial role in repelling the English cavalry?

QUESTION 4

Which English knight famously managed to fight his way back across the bridge after the Scottish attack?

QUESTION 5

According to the contemporary English chronicler Walter of Guisborough, approximately how many English infantry and cavalry were killed?



Visual Question:

Identify the actor in this scene from the famous 1995 film *Braveheart*, which depicts the life of William Wallace and the Battle of Stirling Bridge. 20TH CENTURY FOX FILM CORP

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1.

Vilkanundu Swapnangal was Mammootty’s first credited role, where he played the antagonist. However, his first appearance on screen was in a movie released almost 10 years before. **Ans: Anubhavangal Palichakal**

2. In 2010, the prolific actor released a memoir about his early life. **Ans: Chamayangal**

3. Mammootty and Mohanlal have acted side-by-side in a lot of films. One of the most popular films was *Harikrishnans*, released in 1998. A popular Bollywood actor was the female lead in the film. Name the actor. **Ans: Juhi Chawla**

4. In 2017, this film of Mammootty wherein he played a police officer was criticised by actor Parvathy for

glorifying misogyny. **Ans: Kasaba**

5. This film by Jabbar Patel won Mammootty national fame for playing this iconic economist, social reformer and politician. **Ans: Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar**

6. The Jabbar Patel film is not the only movie in which Mammootty played a political icon. This 2019 film saw him bringing to life this leader who was the Chief Minister of a southern State. Name the film and the leader. **Ans: Yatra; Y. S. Rajasekhara Reddy**

Visual: This still of Mammootty and Bollywood actor Aishwarya Rai is from a Tamil movie, which was an adaption of a Jane Austen novel. **Ans: Kandukondain Kandukondain; Sense and Sensibility**

Early Birds: K.N. Viswanathan | Abhay Krishan | Varghese Joseph | Shanavas Aboobaker | Prem Nath Tiwari



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

“What are you reading?
“An article on global warming. It says here that the weather in our country....”
“.... I’m not interested. Right now I am only interested in finishing”
“... how do you pronounce e..q..u..a..b..l..e?”
“What?”
“E..q..u..a..b..l..e.”
“Well, the first ‘e’ is like the ‘e’ in ‘set’, ‘bet’, and ‘met’. The ‘qu’ sounds like the ‘qu’ in ‘quality’, ‘quit’, and ‘quick’. The ‘a’ is like the....”
“It’s like the ‘a’ in ‘China’, while the final ‘ble’ is probably like the ‘ble’ in ‘bubble’, ‘trouble’, and ‘double’.”
“Exactly! The main stress is on the first syllable. Any idea what the word means?”
“Sure I do. People usually talk about an ‘equable settlement’. That....”
“....sorry! The word you are thinking of is ‘equitable’, not ‘equable’.”
“What’s the difference?”
“When you say that something is ‘equable’, it means it is regular, moderate, free from extremes. The word is often used to refer to the climate. For example, the climate in Rajasthan is anything but equable.”
“Many people say that Hyderabad has an equable climate.”
“You must be joking. Hyderabad gets really hot during the summer. I have heard quite a few people say that Bangalore is equable. But let’s not get into an argument over the weather. Can ‘equable’ be used with people as well?”
“Yes, it can. When you say that someone is ‘equable’ what you are implying is that the person is even tempered.”
“In other words, the individual has no mood swings. Like the climate, the person has no extremes.”
“I guess you could say that. No matter what the situation is, the individual is calm and cheerful. Like me!”
“Like you? You must be joking! How about this example? It’s a pleasure working with Gitanjali because she is so equable.”
“That’s a good example. His equable temperament made Bala quite a popular teacher.”
“Everyone had told Venkat that his new boss was equable and that he would enjoy working with him. So he was quite surprised when the man snapped at him for coming late to office.”
“Bosses are so unpredictable. Tell me, what does ‘eQUITable’ mean?”
“The stress is on the first syllable. It’s pronounced Equitable.”
“I see. What does Equitable mean?”
“It means just or impartial.”
“I see. The Minister has asked the management and the union to come up with an equitable compromise. How does that sound?”
“Good. The lawyer ensured that there was an equitable division of property among the three brothers.”
“The two parties were interested in arriving at an equitable settlement.”
“It’s very difficult to arrive at an equitable compromise.”
“I know. By the way, how is your friend Dilip doing? Has he found a job?”
“No, he hasn’t. He keeps ringing me up every day and talks to me for hours. I feel sorry for him. But there are times when he drives me up the wall.”
“Drives you up the wall?”
“When you say that someone is driving you up the wall, it means that the individual is driving you crazy.”
“So it’s the same thing as ‘driving someone nuts’.”
“That’s right.”

Published in *The Hindu* on December 11, 2001

Word of the day

Punctilious:

marked by precise accordance with details

Synonyms: careful, meticulous, scrupulous

Usage: She is punctilious about following the rules.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/punctilious

International Phonetic Alphabet: /pʌŋkʃtɪliəs/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Text & Context’

INBRIEF



Rupee slumps 44 paise to close at 95.52 against dollar

The rupee depreciated 44 paise to close at 95.52 against the U.S. dollar on Thursday, as Brent crude breached the USD 102 threshold, mounting concerns over the country's import cost trajectory. Forex traders said the currency is currently facing opposing forces, with downside pressure driven by a resumption of foreign portfolio outflows, following positive flows in July and August and crude oil trading above \$102 per barrel. PTI

Ultraviolette to establish 'BIGGA' factory in Hosur

Electric two-wheeler maker Ultraviolette said it would be setting up a Big Global Ambition (BIGGA) factory in Hosur, Tamil Nadu. The facility will provide capacity and infrastructure required to support the company's next phase of growth in India and international markets. The facility will manufacture Tesseract e-scooters, and provide the capacity and scale to support the company's future product portfolio across multiple segments including Sports, Crossover, Cruiser, Street and Scooters, the company said.

OALP deepwater bidding deadline extended till Nov. 15

The Directorate General of Hydrocarbons (DGH) has extended the deadline for submitting bids for deepwater and ultra-deepwater blocks under the 10th and 11th rounds of the Open Acreage Licensing Policy (OALP) by nearly two months until November 15. The revised deadline replaces the earlier September 17 cut-off. Bidding for onland and shallow-water blocks under the two rounds has already closed. The 10th OALP round was opened in April last year, while the 11th round was opened in March this year.

Canara Bank to raise up to ₹4,500 cr. through AT-I bonds

Canara Bank on Thursday said it would raise up to ₹4,500 crore through Basel III-compliant Additional Tier 1 (AT-I) bonds. This offer of issuance is part of a capital-raising proposal where the bank had been authorised by its Board of Directors to raise an amount up to ₹4,500 crore through AT-I bonds and ₹4,000 crore through Tier 2 bonds, the lender said in a statement. The proposed AT-I bonds would be perpetual debt instruments with a call option of five years, subject to regulatory clearance.

Allana eyes ₹40,000 crore India turnover in three years

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Allana Group, one of India's largest processed food and agri-products exporters, is looking to sharply scale up its India business over the next three years, targeting turnover of ₹40,000 crore from around ₹24,000 crore currently, even as it plans to exit select low-margin businesses and pursue strategic acquisitions.

The group's portfolio rejig will be a key part of the growth strategy, with the company evaluating businesses that do not meet its margin and strategic objectives. "Our immediate priorities will be to rebalance our product portfolio by exiting low-margin businesses and certain strategic acquisitions," Manish Bandlish, Group Managing Director, Allana Group, said. The company has not disclosed which businesses could be exited.

The group plans to deploy capital towards higher-growth segments, with protein, poultry, consumer foods and international operations emerging as key priorities.



Allana Group plans to deploy capital towards higher-growth segments. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Protein will remain the group's core business, with Allana planning to add processing capacity and invest in technology and supporting infrastructure. It also plans to set up two green-field manufacturing facilities. "Over the medium to long term, we will strengthen the core protein business, build an integrated poultry platform, and accelerate our consumer brands and international businesses. We are ready to cater to the evolving consumer and the emerging categories shaping the next generation of consumption," he said.

The group is simultaneously building an integrated poultry platform through Indian Poultry Alliance, for which it has

made an initial commitment of \$120 million. The venture will span breeder farms, hatcheries, feed plants, contract farming, value-added poultry products and rendering facilities.

Beyond its traditional meat and agri-products businesses, Allana sees opportunities in pet food, coffee, processed fruits, protein-led products, bakery and frozen foods. These categories are expected to support portfolio expansion as demand shifts towards convenience and protein-rich food products.

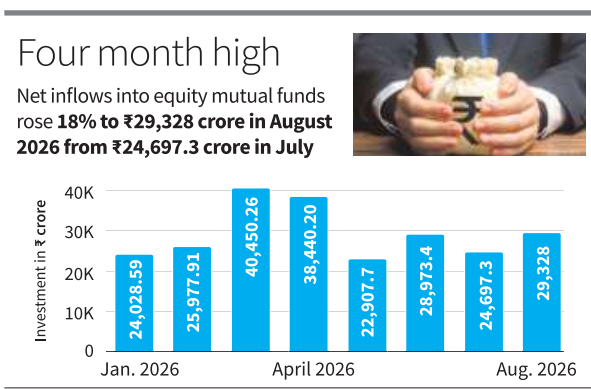
Founded in 1865 as an agri-commodity trading business, Allana has evolved into a diversified food-processing and export group. Its latest strategy marks a shift towards higher-value businesses and consumer-facing categories as it seeks to drive its India turnover to ₹40,000 crore over the next three years. As part of its three-year growth plan, the company plans to add manufacturing capacity across consumer food categories while expanding its distribution and brand presence.

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Net inflows into equity mutual funds rose 18% to a four-month high of ₹29,328 crore in August 2026, even as investor contributions through systematic investment plans (SIPs) plateaued for the third consecutive month, according to data from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE).

Mutual fund investors poured ₹24,697.3 crore into the market in July 2026, which was 15% lower than the June inflows of ₹28,973 crore. As a result, the August figures appear higher largely because they are being compared with the relatively low base recorded in July 2026.

SIP contributions stood at ₹32,297 crore during the



reporting month, up just 1.5% over July 2026 level. The modest increase marks the third consecutive month in which the pace of SIP growth has plateaued, indicating a slowdown in incremental investor contributions through the route.

"Overall, the aggregate collection number does not tell the complete story. Beneath the headline

flows, there appears to be a meaningful rotation of investor capital away from large-cap and some diversified strategies towards mid-cap, small-cap and select hybrid categories. The key question going forward is whether this represents a sustained structural shift in asset allocation or simply a continuation of performance-led flows into segments that have

Bahrain court bins claims in HDFC Credit Suisse bond case

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

HDFC Bank said it secured favourable orders from High Civil Court, Bahrain, in two proceedings initiated by Credit Suisse Additional Tier 1 Bond (CS AT1), investors following judicial scrutiny of claims and evidentiary materials placed before the Bahrain Court.

Between July and August 2026, the Bahrain Court also rejected five other similar matters concerning investors of CS AT1, HDFC Bank said.

The seven investors alleged gross negligence, intentional misrepresentation, incorrect customer classification, non-disclosure of product features/characteristics, misuse of financial leverage and violation of product suitability principles with respect to their investment in CS AT1 Bonds through the Bank. All the allegations were



The court also rejected five other similar matters.

rejected outright by the Court, HDFC Bank said.

"The Bahrain Court rejected their claims outright after finding the investors failed to produce sufficient admissible evidence to prove/substantiate the allegations against the bank or that they suffered any loss owing to the bank," it said.

"In all the seven judgments by the Bahrain Court, the investors were ordered to bear the costs of the proceedings," it added. The favourable out-

comes follow dismissal by the National Consumer Dispute Redressal Commission in India in March of complaints by the bond investors against the bank.

"In its order, NCDRC affirmed the bank was only a facilitator and the investors had full autonomy to make investments in CS AT1 Bonds as per choice and the investors voluntarily chose to make the investments and complained against the bank only after the investments failed to give expected returns and that the investors were well versed with the nuances of the investments at the time of investing," HDFC Bank said.

"The bank is not in the business of underwriting investments made by customers out of own judgment and it will therefore defend itself rigorously against any unsubstantiated claims," the private sector lender added.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has remanded to the Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT) a dispute concerning a ₹5.25-crore penalty imposed by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on Cairn India, now part of Vedanta Limited, over an allegedly misleading advertisement for a proposed buyback of shares in 2014.

A Bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and K.V. Viswanathan held that the release of money kept in escrow for the proposed buyback did not, by itself, prevent SEBI from separately examining whether the company had committed fraud under the SEBI (Prohibition of Fraudulent and Unfair Trade Practices) Regulations, 2003 (PFUTP Regulations).

"The mere release of the escrow does not create an automatic statutory bar to proceedings under the PFUTP Regulations because the release of the escrow is not necessarily equivalent to the absence of fraud," the Bench said.

The top court, however, found that SAT had not ex-



The SC clarified that its observations should not influence SAT's findings

amined an apparent discrepancy between SEBI's investigation report and a letter issued by the National Stock Exchange (NSE), describing the omission as a "material infirmity" that went to the root of the adjudicating officer's order.

"Since this is a material infirmity going to the evidentiary root of the AO's order, one which SAT itself never examined or adjudicated upon, we are of the view that the matter ought to be remanded to SAT so as to enable it to render a considered finding on this specific aspect, upon a proper examination of the record," the Bench said in its 41-page ruling.

The Bench accordingly directed SAT to undertake a fresh scrutiny of the trading data produced by both

sides, including the NSE records, and ascertain which version reliably reflected the transactions in question.

"Upon doing so, SAT shall record specific findings on each of the instances of discrepancy noted hereinabove, as also any other such discrepancy that may be brought to its notice," the Bench said.

It further said that SAT could exercise its powers under Section 15U(2) of the SEBI Act to summon and examine company officials, merchant bankers and others connected with the transactions, as well as call for documents necessary to establish the circumstances in which buy orders were placed during the buyback period.

The top court, however, clarified that its observations should not influence the tribunal's findings and gave it six months to complete the exercise.

"SAT may thereafter render fresh findings on the question of fraud under the PFUTP Regulations, uninfluenced by any observations made by this Court in the course of the present judgment on the merits of the controversy,

'Seeds Bill will not harm farmer rights'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Thursday said the proposed Seeds Bill would not be detrimental to the rights of farmers. Mr. Chouhan, who met about 20 farmers' organisations over the draft Seeds Bill and the Pesticides Management Bill, told their leaders that the Centre would finalise every policy on the basis of consensus after discussions with farmers.

Talking to reporters after the meeting Mr. Chouhan said the Seeds Bill passed in 1966 was no longer in tune with the contemporary farming practices.

He said 70% of seeds used by Indian farmers were outside the purview of the existing Act and it was necessary to crack down on "fake" seeds. He said the government was committed to protecting farmers' rights and that



Shivraj Singh Chouhan

traditional seeds would be conserved. "A traceability system will make it easier for farmers to identify the right seed," he said.

Union Agriculture Secretary Atish Chandra and other senior officials also attended the meeting. Leaders of the Sangh Parivar's farmers outfit Bharatiya Kisan Sangh, various factions of Bharatiya Kisan Union, All India Kisan Coordination Committee (AIKCC), Kisan Mahapanchayat and several other organisations presented their views on the Bills. Mr. Chouhan said there was a need for a new Pesticide Management Act to identify substandard pesticides.

'PepsiCo eyes India as top 10 anchor market'

Rahul Karmakar
NALBARI (ASSAM)

Food and beverage manufacturer PepsiCo opened its first foods factory in the Northeast, a geographically-challenged region not among India's preferred investment zones.

This is PepsiCo's fifth foods manufacturing plant in India. Jagrut Kotecha, CEO, PepsiCo India and South Asia, said the unit was part of the firm's investment commitment through 2030.

"This investment underscores the confidence that leading global companies have in Assam's business-friendly policies, infrastructure development and skilled workforce," CM Himanta Biswa Sarma said.

He underscored the firm's commitment to ensure over 75% of its 700 direct staff are women.

"With our Assam, Madhya Pradesh and Tamil Na-



The plant is spread across 44.2 acre in Danguapara.

du operations, we hope to place India among our top 10 markets," he added.

For agri-entrepreneurs PepsiCo plans to cover 80,000 smallholder farmers by nurturing 2,200 agri-entrepreneurs across Assam and West Bengal.

The new unit will drive demand for more cold storage capacity, boosting Assam's agricultural infrastructure and potato value chain, he said.

'India's 2026 oil demand to hasten by 0.06 mb/d'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India's oil demand is likely to rise by about 0.06 million barrels per day (mb/d) in 2026 and accelerate further by 0.4 mb/d in 2027 on resilient economic growth and sustained demand for hydrocarbon fuels, the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) said in its latest monthly report.

OPEC expects India's oil use to average 5.7 mb/d in 2026, up from the previous year, with gasoline and diesel demand staying elevated on increased road mobility and higher vehicle sales. India's local growth momentum was resilient, supported by 'robust domestic demand and strong services,' despite global trade uncertainties and geopolitical headwinds, OPEC said.

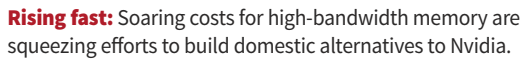
India's coal demand expected to jump 4.2%: IEA

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Coal demand in India is expected to increase by 4.2% year-on-year to 1,353 million tonnes (MT) in 2026 with production expected to scale yet another record at 1,095 MT, the International Energy Agency (IEA) said in its mid-year report Thursday.

The IEA attributed this to government's objective of addressing elevated domestic and industrial demand by focussing efforts on bolstering domestic supply, reducing import dependence and utilising already-elevated stocks at mine pileheads.

In contrast, the IEA sees global coal demand to increase 1.2% to 8.94 billion tonnes (BT) during the same period although production may slide downwards 2% but remaining about 9 BT. IEA attributes projections about elevated coal demand in India to enhanced requirement for power - notwithstanding the spike in renewable sources-based power capacities - alongside El Niño conditions.



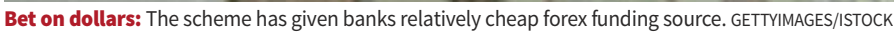
The people declined to be identified because the pricing discussions are not public.

Huawei has said the Ascend 950 series will use two proprietary HBM technologies: HBL 1.0 for the 950PR and HiZQ 2.0 for the 950DT, without detailing where or how the memory is manufactured. The 950DT is built mainly for developing AI models and generating responses, while the 950PR processes user requests before they are passed to the model.

FCNR(B) deposits: Understanding who finally bears the foreign exchange risk

The RBI swap shields banks from currency risk on the principal, while banks have to manage dollar interest payments themselves, leaving some exposed if the rupee weakens; some banks have planned to buy U.S. dollars when they actually need to make the interest payments

The RBI's special swap facility shields banks from foreign-exchange risk on the principal amount of the FCNR(B) deposits. *Reuters* reported that the interest payments, however,



The RBI has received fo-

reign currency through the deposits, adding to the country's reserves. SBI Research said the RBI had recouped \$31.2 billion of its foreign-currency assets by August 7, 2026, equivalent to 55% of the amount mobilised at that point. It also said the RBI may use part of the amount to invest in

SBI Research assumed FCNR(B) mobilisation of \$65-70 billion and a 3% annual hedging cost, and calculated an annual notional cost of about \$2.1 billion. If that cost remained at 3% for five years, the cumulative cost would be about \$10.5 billion.

Edgy bond investors unconsoled by big buyback

The market response underscored the limits of buy-backs as a tool for controll-

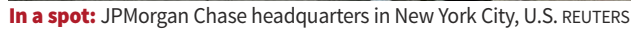
Jim Barnes, director of fixed income at Bryn Mawr Trust in Berwyn, Pennsylvania, said investors may have been unnerved by the Treasury's "pro-active-ness" in attempting to low-

The disappointment reflects changing expectations around Treasury buybacks. Initially viewed as a tool to improve market li-

But the larger buyback announcement failed to convince investors it would materially improve the supply-demand balance in longer-dated bonds. The market's response suggests that Treasury faces a high bar to contain yields. A buyback three times larger than its previous operation was not enough to reverse the recent bond selloff, leaving investors to focus on whether Treasury is willing to scale up purchases as long-term yields rise, or undertake more market-supportive action. Finally, market participants believe buybacks are a temporary solution to long-term problems.

Capital One, JPMorgan bet fighting Trump safer than settling

But settling could be more hazardous. It could encourage lawsuits from many other customers claiming they were similar-



Capital One and JPMorgan have cited that discretion in their defences.”

QUITO

Rubio defends anti-drug boat strikes, warns of cartel ‘cancer’



U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio defended controversial strikes on suspected drug-trafficking boats during a visit to Ecuador on Wednesday, arguing Latin American cartels would “eat these countries alive” if left unchecked. “It’s like a cancer that continues to grow until you don’t literally have a state anymore,” he said. AFP

BERLIN

NATO will stay ‘strong’ whoever wins French election, says Rutte



NATO chief Mark Rutte said on Thursday that the alliance would remain “strong” whoever wins next year’s presidential election in member state France. Polls show that far-right leader Marine Le Pen — who has questioned France’s role in NATO and support for Ukraine — has her best shot of winning the presidency. AFP

KYIV

Russian strike on shopping centre in Ukraine kills at least four people



A Russian strike on a shopping centre in the central Ukrainian city of Pavlodar on Thursday killed at least four people and wounded 60 more, according to the authorities. Meanwhile, in Russia’s Belgorod region, a Ukrainian drone strike on the town of Novy Oskol killed one person and wounded six others. AFP

BEIJING

At least 20 dead, 5 missing after ship catches fire in China’s port



A cargo ship docked for repairs in a Chinese port caught fire, killing at least 20 people and leaving five others missing, Chinese state media reported on Thursday. Of 42 people who had been on the vessel, *Ocean Melody*, which was being repaired at the port of Qingdao, 12 were safely evacuated. AP

Houthis seize key city on Red Sea, advance towards Bab el-Mandeb

The Yemeni group seizes Zuqar Island on the Red Sea, ‘after rocket attacks and a ground assault carried out using boats transporting fighters’; Saudi Arabia conducted ‘40 strikes in recent hours in Taiz, Hodeida, Al-Jawf, Marib’, the group says

Agence France-Presse
SANAA

Yemen’s Houthis seized control of the strategic Red Sea port city of Mokha on Thursday, a Yemeni military source said, as the group reported new strikes by Saudi forces.

The Iran-backed Houthis, who control large parts of northwest Yemen, launched a large-scale offensive last week against Yemeni government forces, who are backed by Saudi Arabia. They also launched attacks on Saudi territory that left dozens of people wounded, in a conflict that has reignited during the war on Iran that be-



Loyal fighters: Houthi rebels march during a mobilisation campaign in Sanaa, Yemen, on Thursday. AP

gan with U.S.-Israeli strikes on Tehran in late February. Witnesses said they saw Houthi forces entering Mokha on Thursday chanting “death to America, death to Israel”.

The Yemeni military source said they were advancing towards the strategic Bab el-Mandeb strait “after having taken control of Mokha”. The waterway, which links Asia to Europe

via the Red Sea and Suez Canal, has gained importance as a transit route since the start of the wider war, which saw Iran blockade the Strait of Hormuz.

The military source said the Houthis also seized Zuqar Island, in the southern Red Sea, “after rocket attacks and a ground assault carried out using boats transporting fighters”.

Also on Thursday, the Houthis reported air strikes. “The Saudi enemy’s air force conducted around 40 strikes in recent hours in the governorates of Taiz, Hodeida, Al-Jawf and Marib,” Houthi news agency *Saba* said.

Yemen relapsed into war in July after years of re-

lative calm punctured by sporadic violence and deepening poverty. Since last week, the fighting in Yemen has left more than 500 dead, mostly combatants. It has also forced nearly 20,000 people to flee their homes, the International Organization for Migration said on Tuesday.

On Wednesday, the Saudi-led coalition battling the Houthis said the anti-government fighters fired ballistic missiles and drones at several cities in southern Saudi Arabia.

The Houthis triggered the return to hostilities in July when they let an Iranian plane land in defiance of Saudi control of Yemeni airspace.

Sri Lanka top court revokes monk’s presidential pardon

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

In a significant case of the judiciary reversing an executive decision, Sri Lanka’s Supreme Court on Thursday overturned a presidential pardon granted to a reactionary Buddhist monk.

In May 2019, then-President Maithripala Sirisena pardoned controversial monk Galagoda Aththe Gnanasara ‘Thero’ (as Buddhist priests in Sri Lanka are respectfully referred to), leader of the hardline Bodu Bala Sena, who was serving prison term at the time, following conviction for contempt of court and criminal intimidation.

Colombo-based non-governmental organisation Centre for Policy Alternatives (CPA) and Sandya Eknaligoda, wife of dissident



Galagoda Aththe Gnanasara

political cartoonist Prageeth Eknaligoda, forcibly disappeared since 2010, had challenged the pardon. Seven years later, the Supreme Court has ruled that President Sirisena’s action was “arbitrary”, and declared it “null and void”. The ruling assumes significance in the Sinhala Buddhist-majority island nation, where the Buddhist clergy wields considerable religious influence and political power.

Gnanasara Thero rose to prominence in 2012, when he founded the BBS. Widely known for his provocative anti-Muslim remarks and mobilisations, the fire-brand monk, now 51, and his organisation became a prominent symbol for a surging anti-Muslim rhetoric in Sri Lanka after the country’s civil war ended in 2009.

In January 2016, Gnanasara Thero stormed the courtroom and openly threatened Ms. Eknaligoda, when a magistrate court was hearing a case of her disappeared husband.

Two years after Mr. Sirisena pardoned the monk, his successor Gotabaya Rajapaksa appointed Gnanasara Thero to a Presidential Task Force to draft proposals on legal reforms, a move widely criticised by rights defenders.

Jihadists attack strategic Army camp in central Mali

Agence France-Presse
BAMAKO

Jihadists attacked a strategic Mali army base in the central region of Mopti on Thursday, military and local sources said.

Since late April, the al-Qaeda-linked Group for the Support of Islam and Muslims (JNIM) and its Tuareg separatist allies have waged a series of attacks meant to weaken the country’s junta rulers.

Mali’s armed forces said in a statement that the attack was carried out on the Dioura military camp.

Fighting broke out Thursday morning around the military station, which serves as a key forward base for army operations in the area.

“Our positions came under fire this morning, but the situation is now under control with the support of

Since 2012, Mali has been wracked by a security crisis, fuelled by violence from jihadists

our partners,” an Army officer based in Mopti said, referring to the Moscow-backed Africa Corps paramilitary fighters.

Local residents reported intense fighting and a chaotic situation on the ground. “We heard gunfire early in the morning, it was non-stop. Then a few moments later we saw Army pickup trucks speeding from the camp towards the edge of town,” a resident said on condition of anonymity.

Another resident reported that the attackers were “inside the camp” and that a Malian aircraft had been spotted flying ov-

er the area, while noting that the situation “is not completely calm”.

The director of the military public relations service called the attacks “complex” but said that the Army had “managed to destroy the enemy”.

An Army officer based in Mopti said that no casualty figures were yet available and that assessments were under way on the ground. JNIM quickly claimed “total control of a Malian Army barracks in the town of Dioura” on its communication channels.

The Dioura military camp has been attacked several times in recent years by JNIM jihadists and the Tuareg-separatist Azawad Liberation Front.

Mali has been wracked since 2012 by a serious security crisis, notably fuelled by violence from jihadists.

Charred remains



People walk amid the charred remains of homes near a primary school and a secondary school where a fire broke out, killing at least 24 students and injuring dozens, in Bukavu, Congo, on Thursday. The cause of the fire is not known, says a neighbourhood administrator. AP

Algeria cuts diplomatic relations with the UAE

Agence France-Presse
ALGIERS

Algeria said on Thursday it was cutting diplomatic ties with the United Arab Emirates following years of tension, with Algiers accusing Abu Dhabi of interfering in national and regional affairs. In an official statement, Algiers accused the Gulf country of “provocative and hostile acts”, but it remained unclear what triggered the rupture.

Algerian President Abdelmadjid Tebboune has often referred to the UAE as a “micro-state” or “statelet” seeking to destabilise several countries in the region, citing Libya, Mali and Sudan.

The Emirati Foreign Ministry later said it hoped the decision would be temporary.

‘Iran attack on base in Jordan damaged U.S. military aircraft’

Reuters
WASHINGTON

Iranian strikes damaged multiple American military aircraft this week on the Muwaffaq Salti Air Base in Jordan, a U.S. official told *Reuters*.

The U.S. military, the highest-funded in the world, suffered material damage even before Iran’s strikes on Tuesday. This includes the destruction of more than two dozen drones, Iran striking fighter jets, and aircraft being

lost to accidents.

According to a May report from the Congressional Research Service, 42 U.S. military aircraft had already been lost or damaged in the conflict.

A U.S. official said Iran’s attack hit one A-10 Thunderbolt II, known as the Warthog, leaving it with a missing wing, while roughly eight F-15s sustained light damage and were returned to service. Since February, 18 U.S. service members have been killed and over 800 injured.

Trump promises Americans \$5,000 if Republicans win Congress in November

Agence France-Presse
DALLAS

U.S. President Donald Trump on Wednesday promised \$5,000 to every American adult if Republicans retain control of Congress in November, coupling the extraordinary claim with a plea for his supporters to “pretend” he was on the ballot.

“If the Republicans win, you win with us and you get \$5,000. It will be called the Trump dividend,” he told the Republican midterm convention in Dallas, as the party struggles in



U.S. President Donald Trump gestures on stage at the Republican National Midterm Convention in Dallas on Wednesday. REUTERS

polls against the Democrats.

The President did not disclose where the money would come from — with the theoretical bill likely topping \$1 trillion — saying only that “our country is making so much money”.

Doubling down on his

bet that he can help Republicans defy opinion polls and retain both houses of Congress on November 3, Mr. Trump said: “I’m asking you to pretend that I’m on the ballot.”

Opinion polls overwhelmingly show that Mr. Trump’s approval ratings are in the low 30s, as voters become increasingly angry about high prices and the war he launched against Iran.

Decision Desk HQ projects Democrats to win the House 230-205 and the Senate to finish 51-49 in their favour in November.

Saima Wazed resigns as WHO Southeast Asia regional director

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

Saima Wazed, daughter of former Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, resigned as the World Health Organisation’s regional director for Southeast Asia.

The resignation, according to sources, comes after member states recommended the termination of her appointment, bringing her five-year term to an end. She assumed office on February 1, 2024. Ms. Wazed’s tenure was marked

by fraud-related investigations by both the WHO and Bangladeshi authorities.

Ms. Wazed’s resignation takes effect immediately. The WHO is expected to invite nominations for her successor in October. The Southeast Asia Region comprises 10 member states, including India and Bangladesh.

Ms. Wazed was placed on leave in 2025 after Bangladesh’s anti-corruption commission filed fraud and forgery charges against her.



Kim Ju-ae, Kim Jong-un's daughter, is being groomed as his successor, assesses South Korea's spy agency. AFP

Kim Jong-un may have another child: Seoul spy agency

Agence France-Presse
SEOUL

North Korean leader Kim Jong-un's daughter and apparent successor is believed to have a younger sibling, South Korea's spy agency said on Thursday, offering a more detailed view of the ruling family's line of succession.

Seoul's spy agency has previously said Mr. Kim is thought to have three children, but some uncertainty remains on the number of offspring as well as the order of their birth.

The Kim dynasty is now in its third generation ruling the closed-off nation, and the current leader's children would be potentially poised to take over one day. Mr. Kim's daughter, Kim Ju-ae, was first introduced to the public in 2022 when she accompanied her father to the launch of an inter-continental ballistic missile.

Seoul had initially indicated that Mr. Kim and his wife Ri Sol-ju had their first child, a boy, in 2010, and that Kim Ju-ae was their second child.

But in 2023, Seoul's unification minister said that the government was "unable to confirm" the existence of the son. The child described Thursday by South Korea's spy agency would be the youngest. "The National Intelligence Service currently assesses that Kim Ju-ae is being groomed as the successor and understands she has a younger sibling of unknown gender," the agency said, reaffirming its conclusion on succession.

North Korea tightly controls information about its leadership and ruling family, leaving even basic details about Kim Jong-un's children difficult to verify.

The NIS added that it was continuing to examine whether Kim Ju-ae has an older brother, but believes that "even if he exists, he is not in a position to become the successor".

Impact of trade restrictions on illegal West Bank settlements remains limited

As many as 12 countries, including the U.K., France, and Canada, have issued a joint statement on introducing new restrictions on trade with illegal Israeli settlements in West Bank; while it reinforces their commitment to the two-state solution, it appears largely symbolic and barely consequential

NEWS ANALYSIS

Sambavi Parthasarathy

The U.K., France, and Canada, along with nine other countries, namely Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Ireland, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Spain and Sweden, issued a joint statement on Tuesday confirming their intention to introduce new restrictions on trade with illegal Israeli settlements in the West Bank. While the U.K., France and Canada announced a trade ban, some have sanctions in process and others have already sanctioned their trade with illegal settlements.

While the joint statement reinforces the commitment of these countries to the two-state solution, it appears largely symbolic and barely consequential.

Rising settler violence

The statement comes in response to the rapidly deteriorating situation 'amid unprecedented levels of settler violence and settlement expansion' in the occupied West Bank and Israel's decision to publish tenders for construction of 1,234 Israeli homes as part of its E1 settlement project that aims to create a continuous settlement 'corridor' between occupied East Jerusalem and Ma'ale Adumim.

This construction on

Palestinian land is illegal under international law and would isolate Palestinian communities between the northern and southern West Bank.

While the E1 settlement project is the latest trigger, Israel has been intensifying its activities in the West Bank since October 7, 2023, resulting in more than a thousand casualties and several thousand injuries.

More than 41,000 Palestinians have been displaced in the West Bank due to settler and Israeli violence as of UNRWA's monthly snapshot released last month. Settler violence has also been escalating. Data from UN OCHA show that more than 3,000 settler attacks resulted in casualties or property damage between January 2025 and July 2026.

Israel also scaled up the expansion of its footprint since October 7, 2023. In less than three years, nearly 5,000 structures, including houses and other infrastructure, have been demolished. That is an average of nearly 5 buildings being demolished in the West Bank each day.

Data from Peace Now, an Israeli activist group tracking settlements, show that settlers established at least 200 outposts (Israeli settlements established without government approval and are considered illegal even under Israeli law) and issued over



Beyond borders: A demonstration against illegal Israeli settlements in the West Bank, outside the Houses of Parliament in central London on Wednesday. AFP

12,000 tenders for construction of housing units in the region since 2023.

While the decision to restrict shipments from Israeli settlements emerged in this backdrop, it is unlikely to deter Israel's illegal activities in the West Bank.

Eight of the 12 countries that issued the joint statement already belong to the European Union which already has a trade policy with respect to goods from Israeli settlements. But that policy itself has several loopholes.

EU policy loopholes

As per existing EU policy, goods originating from Israeli settlements in territo-

ries occupied by Israel since 1967 are not entitled to benefit from preferential tariff treatment.

The EU has ensured this since 2004 via a 'Technical arrangement' between EU and Israel customs authorities by differentiating between products originating in Israel and settlements. Basically, shipments are required to carry proof of origin (names and postal code) to identify the real origin and if so, deny preferential treatment and trade preferences that are granted to Israel under the EU-Israel association agreement.

This existing policy has not deterred illegal settlements from flourishing in

occupied territories. The population of settlers in the West Bank doubled between 2004 and 2025 and trade to the EU from these settlements had eventually found its way.

Palestinian rights legal advocacy group Global Echo, in its 'Importing Occupation' report released in 2026, found that illegal settlement products to the EU are sustained through three principal practices - hiding in plain sight (indicating actual location and postal code of production in occupied territory while designating that location as being in Israel), sham address method (use of proxy or invented address within Israel's recognised borders

instead of disclosing true origin) and mingling method (co-mingling settlement produce with goods from within Israel). The organisation, in its analysis of over 30,000 export documents accompanying over 6,800 shipments of agricultural products from Israel, found that more than 17% of the 5,900 shipments destined for Europe - that is, one in six shipments overall and one in five shipments bound for the EU - originated from illegal settlements.

Lack of impact

These practices, which have already undermined effective application of the EU's trade policy, could still allow products from settlements in the European market despite the restrictions. Further, even if the move by these 12 countries effectively counter these existing loopholes, the intended impact on Israeli activities in the West Bank is not likely to pan out.

This is because these countries continue to harbour their trade activities with Israel, which account for at least \$21 billion. This is over 40% of the value of Israel's trade in goods with the EU, its single largest trading partner.

Meanwhile, trade with settlements amounts only to a fraction of this value which is why it is unlikely to amount to any sort of economic impact/threat.

'Mr. Singh' advertisement by U.S. Homeland Security kicks off row

Press Trust of India
WASHINGTON

An advertisement posted by the Department of Homeland Security asking "Mr. Singh" to self-deport sparked off a controversy with advocacy groups terming it racist and anti-American.

The Department of Homeland Security (DHS) used AI-generated imagery on X to push its campaign against unlicensed commercial drivers, featuring a brown-bearded man with a tagline: "Get off our roads, you don't know how to drive Mr Singh." A video in a related post shows Megatron, the antagonist character in the Transformers franchise, negotiating the



The 'racist' advertisement posted by the DHS on X that sparked off controversy.

release of "aliens" - a term used for foreigners by the U.S. administration.

Megatron is shown seeking the release of truck drivers Harjinder Singh,

Rajinder Kumar, Bekzhan Beishekeev, Akhrror Bozov, and Jasveer Singh, who were involved in road accidents and other crimes. "If you approach this nation with hostile intent, know this. We will defend ourselves. We will defend Americanism. We will defend our home," the DHS said on X.

Another post features Optimus Prime, the main protagonist in the Transformers franchise, with a DHS arm patch confronting the brown-bearded man with the message: "Self-deport or find out."

The reference to "Mr Singh" in the advertisement was criticised by advocacy groups, including the Hindu American Foun-

dation (HAF) and Sikh Coalition. "Singhs are Hindu, they are Sikhs, they are American and they drive. Racist, un-American, anti-Indian profiling/trolling by @DHSgov should shock our nation's collective conscience," HAF said on X.

"Singling out SOME last names does nothing for safe streets, but it does endanger the safety of hundreds of thousands of Americans with names like Singh and Kumar," Coalition of Hindus of North America said.

The row comes amid a DHS campaign to promote its CBP Home programme, which allows eligible undocumented migrants to register their intention to leave the U.S. voluntarily.

Wall of loss



A man looks at photos of missing persons outside a morgue in the aftermath of flash floods in Kathmandu on Wednesday. The tsunami-like surge of water, mud and debris on August 26, which began on the China-Nepal border, killed over 1,410 people and left 5,651 missing. AFP

Twenty-five years since 9/11, Trump's Iran war risks becoming another 'forever war'

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
WASHINGTON

When Donald Trump campaigned for a second term in the White House, he promised to be a "President of peace" who would stop foreign wars, not start them.

Now, a quarter-century after the September 11, 2001, attacks that triggered America's global "war on terror," he is entangled in an unpopular conflict of his own making that analysts say risks becoming his version of a "forever war."

With the 9/11 anniversary at hand, Mr. Trump's war against Iran is drawing comparisons in foreign policy circles to the long, divisive conflicts in Afghan-

istan and Iraq that preceded it. It is also prompting questions about whether the U.S. has again failed to learn the lessons of past conflicts or prepare a clear exit strategy.

"Trump has broken an important post-Iraq and Afghanistan constraint in Washington against launching another major, open-ended war in the Middle East," said Sina Toossi of the Center for International Policy, a Washington think tank. "That could leave his successor inheriting... an entrenched U.S.-Iran confrontation."

Administration officials have said the war against Iran is nothing like the protracted post-9/11 engagements.

During the conflicts in Iraq and Afghanistan, the U.S. removed hostile go-

vernments, committed thousands of ground troops who took and held territory, suffered and inflicted much higher casualties and struggled to instill Western-style governance.

This time, the U.S. is relying mainly on air and naval power, operations that have damaged Iran militarily and economically but have not defeated it or spurred Iranians to overthrow their rulers as Mr. Trump initially urged.

But after six months of war, the United States is mired in a battle of attrition punctuated by bursts of hostilities - exemplified by this week's exchange of attacks on oil tankers - while Mr. Trump tries to tighten the economic noose around Tehran.

Analysts warn it is likely to drag on well past the



Heavy toll: A volunteer holds a toy recovered from a school hit by a U.S. air strike on February 28 in Minab, Iran. AP

U.S. midterm elections in November, when voters' opposition to the war could threaten Mr. Trump's Republican Party's chances of keeping control of Congress.

No obvious exit

And, much like those earlier conflicts, there is no obvious exit even as the

economic costs weigh on U.S. consumers.

Tehran's disruption of oil shipments through the Strait of Hormuz has pushed U.S. gasoline prices higher. The war has weakened Mr. Trump's approval ratings and undermined Washington's international standing, which was also one of the

repercussions from the Iraq and Afghan wars.

Analysts say Mr. Trump has failed to heed the central lessons of the post-9/11 era, which began after al Qaeda militants crashed planes into New York's World Trade Center and the Pentagon outside Washington, killing nearly 3,000 people.

Those include the steep political downsides of long wars and the dangers posed by an entrenched foe fighting for its survival.

The attacks led to decades of conflict, starting with the invasion of Afghanistan, where al Qaeda leaders were sheltering, and followed by the 2003 invasion of Iraq, based on what turned out to be faulty intelligence that it was developing weapons of mass destruction.

The twin wars undertaken by President George W. Bush overstretched the U.S. military and destabilised West Asia.

The resulting U.S. public backlash helped fuel Mr. Trump's rise a decade ago, and he won a second term in 2024 vowing to avoid military adventurism and focus on Americans' economic concerns.

But similar to how the Bush administration underestimated the insurgencies the U.S. would face in Iraq and Afghanistan, Mr. Trump and his aides have miscalculated Iran's resiliency and ability to throttle a fifth of the world's energy shipments, analysts say.

Notably, Mr. Trump's "Operation Epic Fury" launched alongside Israel on February 28 was not

precipitated by a 9/11-type national trauma but was deemed by critics to be a war of choice. Experts have disputed Mr. Trump's claims that Tehran's nuclear programme posed an imminent threat to the U.S.

Iran may be taking a page from Afghanistan's Taliban, who returned to power five years ago after a chaotic U.S. withdrawal, that a determined foe can outlast Washington's superior firepower while domestic pressure erodes its resolve.

The Iran conflict has also illustrated the cost of going to war with few allies on board. The conflict has mirrored the Iraq invasion in terms of a regional spillover that seemed to catch Washington off-guard, in this case Tehran's retaliation against U.S. Gulf allies.

INBRIEF



India makes semifinals with 19-0 demolition of Pakistan

India stormed into the semifinals of the women's junior Asia Cup hockey with a ruthless 19-0 demolition of Pakistan at Moqi (China) on Thursday. Pooja Malik, *in pic.*, scored a hat-trick.

The result: India 19 (Puja Sahoo 7, Roshni Aind 9, 60, Tanushree Kadu 11, Sukhveer Kaur 13-ps, Sanika Mane 13, 23, Madhu Sidar 16, 39, Geeta Yadav 18, Tanuja Toppo 25, Pooja Malik 27, 49, 51, Purnima Yadav 33, Supriya 40, 54, Krishna Sharma 48, Binima Dhan 55) bt Pakistan 0.



Shooter Mona secures 2028 LA Paralympics quota

Indian para-shooter Mona Agarwal on Thursday secured a quota place for the 2028 Paralympic Games in Los Angeles after winning the 10m air rifle standing SHI silver at the WSPS World Championships in Changwon. Avani Lekhara got the bronze but could not secure a quota.

LIVE TELECAST

Namibia vs South Africa: Second ODI, FanCode, 1 p.m.
England vs Pakistan: Third Test, Day 3, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 3.30 p.m.
Women's T20 Asia Cup: Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 8 p.m.
US Open: SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 12.30 & 4.30 a.m. (Saturday).



High expectations: Manush and Manav are ranked No. 3 in the world heading into the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games. FILE PHOTO: SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Manav-Manush pair hopes to make amends

The narrow loss at the Hangzhou Asiad still rankles the duo; the Gujarat paddlers are India's best bet for a medal at the continental extravaganza

TABLE TENNIS

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

India's World No. 3 men's doubles pair of Manav Thakkar and Manush Shah will head into the Asian Games as the country's strongest table tennis medal prospects, carrying with them the lingering disappointment of a near-miss in Hangzhou three years ago.

The Gujarat duo had come within a point of a medal in Hangzhou, before losing a tense quarterfinal to South Korea's Jang Woo-jin and Lim Jong-hoon, the then World No. 1 pair.

The defeat, Manush admitted, continues to rankle.

"It's at the back of the mind. I think the wounds of the last Asian Games haven't healed yet. Me and

Manav both always speak about that match. We want to recover from that loss," Manush told *The Hindu*.

The Indians had a match point against the Korean pair and were left devastated after failing to convert despite matching the top seeds for most of the contest.

Heartbreak

"We were very sad because there were a lot of chances. It wasn't just one chance," Manav said.

"Before the match, we had the belief that we could win. We played well and our decisions were good, but somehow they were better than us."

Since then, the pair has made significant progress on the international circuit, climbing to World No. 2 before slipping to No. 3 heading into the continental extravaganza.

Manav, however, was

wary of letting expectations become a burden.

"It is a very big opportunity. Last time, we missed out on a medal and this time we are No. 3 in the world, so expectations are there," he said.

"We hope to give our best and win a medal for the country. But at the same time, we are enjoying every match and the process."

Keeping it simple

For Manush, the immediate priority remains simpler.

"I always feel the next match is the priority," he said.

"We are enjoying the training and the process. Results are not something we can rely upon, but enjoying the process is something that is constant."

Manav and Manush will hope they can finally redeem themselves.

Yash replaces Harshit; Bumrah, Nitish and Washington declared fit

CRICKET

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

During India's training session at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Thursday, in preparation for the three-match T20I series against Afghanistan beginning on Sunday, a quick headcount of the players in attendance seemed imperative. For, a spate of injuries has plagued India recently, so much so that four of the 15-member squad for the series had asterisks that mandated fitness clearance at the Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Bengaluru.

On Thursday, it became official that Harshit Rana hadn't got the requisite clearance. In his absence, pacer Yash Thakur, who made his debut for India on the tour of Zimbabwe in July, has been drafted in for this series as well as the Asian Games in Japan. The 27-year-old had a lengthy bowl to skipper Shreyas Iyer in the nets on a hot and humid afternoon.

Much to the relief of the Indian camp, Jasprit Bumrah, Nitish Kumar and Washington Sundar have been declared fit.

"Harshit was progressing well during his rehab at CoE. He sustained a rectus femoris strain while bowling during a match simulation on September 7 and has been ruled out," the BCCI release said.

While Washington batted and bowled during



Lucky break: Yash had made his debut against Zimbabwe in July. FILE PHOTO: SANDEEP SAXENA

practice on Thursday, Bumrah and Nitish were among the five players missing from the session. They were yet to arrive from Bengaluru while Ishan Kishan, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and Tilak Varma had to fulfil their commitments in the Duleep Trophy final in Chennai.

Crowd management

With the national capital hosting the BRICS summit over the weekend, the Delhi & District Cricket Association (DDCA) will be taking

additional measures for crowd management during the first T20I. "We have been told to ensure the crowd management is smooth. Car parking will be severely restricted outside the stadium," DDCA secretary Ashok Sharma told *The Hindu*.

The DDCA said the game will go ahead as scheduled. "Following a meeting with Delhi Traffic Police, DDCA has been assured of all necessary arrangements," a statement read.

Indian cricket team physio resigns

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Kamlesh Jain, the head physiotherapist with India's men's cricket team, has submitted his resignation to the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI).

The Hindu understands that while the BCCI is yet to formally accept it, Jain is serving his three-month notice period. Unless relieved earlier by the BCCI, the Chennai-based physio would end his four-year association at the end of India's tour of New Zealand in December.

Jain replaced Nitin Patel as the physio in June 2022, with Patel moving to the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru. Patel has since left the CoE to join Mumbai Indians.

Recruited from Kolkata Knight Riders during Rahul Dravid's tenure as India coach, Jain is believed to have sought a move away from the national team because of the extensive travel involved. Jain was the bridge between the CoE, the selectors and the coaching staff when it came to players' fitness.

France ditches Infantino

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

France will not support the candidacy of Gianni Infantino, who is running for a new term as FIFA president in March 2027, the French Football Federation (FFF) announced on Thursday.

It's Prannoy vs. Sanskar, Tanvi vs. Malvika in the quarterfinals

BADMINTON

Press Trust of India
HO CHI MINH CITY

Veteran H.S. Prannoy will face compatriot Sanskar Saraswat, while Tanvi Sharma will square off against Malvika Bansod in the quarterfinals after the four Indians won their respective matches at the Vietnam Open Super 100 badminton here on Thursday. Third-seeded Prannoy overcame Taiwan's Wu Zhe Ying 21-15, 13-21, 21-14, while Sanskar beat sixth seed Kiran George 12-21, 21-1, 21-18 in the pre-quarterfinals.

Top seed Tanvi was tested by Thailand's Passa-Orn Phannachet before prevail-

ing 26-24, 21-12, while Malvika defeated Tidapron Kleeyesun 21-19, 21-14.

Third seed Isharani Baruah also entered the quarters with a 21-18, 21-16 win over Malaysia's Goh Jin Wei. She will take on Taiwan's Huang Ching Ping in the quarterfinals.

Mansi Singh, who finished runner-up at the Indonesia Masters Super 100 last week, continued her good run by defeating China's Xu Wen Jing 23-21, 21-19 and will meet sixth seeded fellow Indian Rakshitha Sree Santhosh Ramraj, who beat South Korea's Kim Min Sun 21-13, 22-20.

Tharun Manneppalli and Alap Mishra, however, failed to progress beyond the pre-quarterfinals.

Tharun lost 14-21, 13-21

to Vietnam's Nguyen Hai Dang, while Alap was beaten 15-21, 9-21 by China's fifth seed Dong Tian Yao.

The results

(pre-quarterfinals): Men: Nguyen Hai Dang bt Tharun Manneppalli 21-14, 21-13; Dong Tian Yao bt Alap Mishra 21-15, 21-9; Zhu Xuan Chen bt Rounak Chouhan 21-16, 11-21, 25-23; H.S. Prannoy bt Wu Zhe Ying 21-15, 13-21, 21-14; Sanskar Saraswat bt Kiran George 12-21, 21-1, 21-18.

Women: Tanvi Sharma bt Passa-Orn Phannachet 26-24, 21-12; Malvika Bansod bt Tidapron Kleeyesun 21-19, 21-14; Isharani Baruah bt Goh Jin Wei 21-18, 21-16; Mansi Singh bt Xu Wen Jing 23-21, 21-19; Rakshitha Sree Santhosh Ramraj bt Kim Min Sun 21-13, 22-20.

Mixed doubles: Vimalraj Annadurai & Shreya Balaji bt Sathwik Reddy Kanapuram & Radhika Sharma 21-15, 24-22.

Anahat, Abhay face Malaysian challenge

SQUASH

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India's Abhay Singh has been seeded second in the men's squash singles draw while Anahat Singh has been seeded third in women's singles as both push for the gold medal in the Asian Games, also securing qualification for the 2028 Olympics in the process.

The seedings, announced on Thursday, were done considering the World rankings as of July 13. While India has won three gold medals in the Asian Games, it is yet to step on the top of the singles podium.

Squash will make its Olympics debut in couple of years and the singles



Eyeing glory: Abhay has been seeded second in men's singles while Anahat is seeded third. FILE PHOTOS: B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM



winners of the Asian Games earn direct qualification for the 2028 Summers Games in Los Angeles.

Anahat is expected to win a medal at the Asian Games. The World No. 20's main competitors include fifth-ranked and defending champion Sivasangari Sub-

ramaniam of Malaysia and sixth-ranked Satomi Watanabe of Japan. Tanvi Khanna, another Indian in the women's singles draw, has been seeded seventh.

In men's singles, 24th-ranked Abhay has been given the second seeding behind 18th-ranked defending champion Eain Yow Mg

of Malaysia. Veer Chotrani has been seeded fourth.

Veteran Joshna Chinappa will be seen in action in mixed doubles and women's team events in her record seventh consecutive Asian Games appearance.

The Indian men's team comprising Abhay, Chotrani, Velavan Senthilkumar and Suraj Kumar Chand is the top seed ahead of Malaysia, Pakistan and Hong Kong. The Anahat-led women's team has been seeded third.

India had won won the men's team and mixed doubles gold in the previous edition in Hangzhou. Abhay was part of the men's team while the mixed doubles gold came through Harinder Pal Sandhu and Dipika Pallikal.

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

Seam-bowling all-rounders are precious commodities. No team knows that better than India, which has often had a vexing search for multifaceted options who can bat in the top seven and bowl fast. Even when such cricketers come along, like in the cases of Hardik Pandya and Nitish Kumar, the spectre of injury tends to loom large.

Currently, Afghanistan doesn't face that predicament due to the regular presence of Azmatullah Omarzai. In the past couple of years, the 26-year-old has established himself as one of the leading all-rounders in the world in white-ball cricket. He won the ICC ODI Cricketer of the Year award for his exploits in 2024.



Top performer: All-rounder Omarzai is one of the best in the business. FILE PHOTO: SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Omarzai is gearing up for three T20Is against India at the Arun Jaitley Stadium from September 13 to 17. The assignment, where Afghanistan will be the official host, follows a one-off Test and three ODIs against India in June. With the Afghans getting to rub shoul-

ders with India's marquee players more frequently, especially in the IPL, Omarzai feels they are no longer overawed.

"We used to watch the big names on TV and now we play with them. When we play internationally, we don't feel extra pressure.

We are used to playing big matches in front of big crowds. There is no fear playing against India. All the players are on an equal footing," Omarzai said over a Zoom call.

In the absence of top-notch facilities in Kabul, Afghanistan shuffles between India and the UAE for its 'home' matches. According to Omarzai, it is far from ideal to not have a dedicated home venue. "It is difficult. The conditions in the UAE and Kabul are similar. That is why we are more successful in the UAE. We try to adjust wherever we go. We don't get home advantage like other countries do because they play at home," he noted.

(*Watch Afghanistan vs India live and exclusive on Sony Sports Ten 5 SD & HD on September 13 from 7.30 p.m.*)

Mix of youth and experience in Brazil squad for India visit

Agencies
RIO DE JANEIRO

Chelsea forwards Joao Pedro and Estevao were recalled on Wednesday to Brazil's squad for the September and October friendlies against Australia and India as coach Carlo Ancelotti begins rebuilding the National team.

In his first squad since Brazil's failed World Cup campaign, Ancelotti included many new faces, among them goalkeepers Pedro Morisco and Otavio, defender Mauro Junior, and midfielders Breno Bidon and Gabriel Bontempo.

Several of the stars return, including forwards Vinicius Junior and Ra-



Pedro, REUTERS

phinha, midfielder Bruno Guimaraes and central defenders Gabriel Magalhaes and Marquinhos.

The Brazil team will face Australia in Townsville on September 25 and Brisbane on September 29 before taking on India for the first time in Kolkata on Oc-

tober 3. "We have to make a balanced list, with players who played in the last campaign and young players who can bring new energy to the team. The idea is to build something for the future without losing our competitiveness," said Ancelotti.

The squad: Goalkeepers: Hugo Souza, Pedro Morisco, Otavio. **Defenders:** Arthur Dias, Douglas Santos, Gabriel Magalhaes, Jair Cunha, Marquinhos, Matheusinho, Mauro Junior, Vitor Reis, Wesley. **Midfielders:** Andrey Santos, Breno Bidon, Bruno Guimaraes, Danilo, Douglas Luiz, Gabriel Bontempo. **Forwards:** Endrick, Vinicius Junior, Estevao, Joao Pedro, Pedro, Samuel Lino, Raphinha, Rayan.

